The Noble Mahāyāna Sūtra "The Display of Amitābha"

Āryāmitābhavyūhanāmamahāyānasūtra · Toh 49 · Derge Kangyur
འཕགས་པ་འདོད་དཔག་མེད་ཀྱི་ཁྱོན་ཀྱི་པ་ཧན་བྱ་ཐེག་པ་ཆེན་པའོ་མདོ།

The Noble Great Vehicle Sūtra called The Display of Amitābha, known in Sanskrit as the Ārya Amitābhavyūha Nāma Mahāyāna Sūtra and in Tibetan as Pakpa Ö Pakmé Kyi Köpa, is a Mahāyāna sūtra devoted to the buddha Amitābha and the splendor of his realm. It opens with the Buddha at Vulture Peak Mountain near Rājagṛha, surrounded by a great assembly of thirty-two thousand monks who are all arhats. It then describes Amitābha's buddhafield, the pure land of Sukhāvatī, and the aspirations through which it came to be, and it is closely related to the larger Sukhāvatīvyūha tradition so influential in East Asian Pure Land Buddhism. It is Toh 49 in the Kangyur, where it appears as the fifth chapter of the Heap of Jewels, or Ratnakūṭa, the great collection of Mahāyāna sūtras.

From the Dharma discourse of the noble Great Heap of Jewels in a hundred thousand chapters, the fifth chapter: The Display of Amitābha. The first fascicle.

In the language of India: ārya amitābha byuha nāma mahāyāna sūtra. In the language of Tibet: The Noble Great Vehicle Sūtra called The Display of Amitābha.

Homage to all the buddhas and bodhisattvas.

Thus did I hear at one time. The Blessed One was staying at Rājagṛha, on Vulture Peak Mountain, together with a great Saṅgha of thirty-two thousand monks. All of them were arhats. Their defilements were exhausted, and they were free of afflictions. They were steadfast in their abiding. Their minds were thoroughly liberated by perfect knowledge, and their fetters to existence were completely exhausted. They had attained their own aim, they were victorious, and they had reached the supreme state of discipline and peace. Their minds were thoroughly liberated, and their wisdom was thoroughly liberated. They were thoroughbreds and great elephants. They possessed the six superknowledges and had gained mastery. They dwelt in meditation on the eight liberations, had attained the powers, and had superknowledge. All of them were great elder śrāvakas, namely:

the venerable Ājñātakauṇḍinya, the venerable Aśvajit, the venerable Vāṣpa, the venerable Mahānāman, the venerable Bhadrajit, the venerable Yaśodeva, the venerable Vimala, the venerable Subāhu, the venerable Pūrṇa, the venerable Gavāṃpati, the venerable Uruvilvākāśyapa, the venerable Nadīkāśyapa, the venerable Gayākāśyapa, the venerable Kumārakāśyapa, the venerable Mahākāśyapa, the venerable Śāriputra, the venerable Mahāmaudgalyāyana, the venerable Mahākauṣṭhila, the venerable Mahākapphiṇa, the venerable Mahācunda, the venerable Aniruddha, the venerable Accomplished One, the venerable Nandika, the venerable Kimpila, the venerable Subhūti, the venerable Revata, the venerable Khadiravanika, the venerable Vakkula, the venerable Svāgata, the venerable Amogharāja, the venerable Pāragāmika, the venerable Panthaka, the venerable Cūḍapanthaka, the venerable Rāhula, and the venerable Nanda.

These and others besides were all great elder śrāvakas endowed with superknowledge, with the exception of one person, namely the venerable Ānanda, who still had further work to do on the path of training. He was also accompanied by many bodhisattva great beings, Maitreya and others.

Then the venerable Ānanda rose from his seat, draped his upper robe over one shoulder, and knelt with his right knee on the ground. Bowing with palms joined toward the Blessed One, he said to the Blessed One:

"Blessed One, your faculties are utterly serene, the color of your face is completely pure, and the hue of your skin is perfectly clear and golden. Just as, for example, a pale yellow autumn cloth that is completely pure and thoroughly cleansed looks golden, in the same way the faculties of the Blessed One are utterly serene, the color of his face is completely pure, and the hue of his skin is perfectly clear and golden.

"Venerable Blessed One, it is just as when gold from the Jambū River, refined a hundredfold, is placed in a crucible by a skilled goldsmith or a goldsmith's apprentice, thoroughly refined, and then laid upon a yellow woolen cloth: it becomes utterly pure, perfectly clear, and golden. In the same way the faculties of the Blessed One are utterly serene, the color of his face is completely pure, and the hue of his skin is perfectly clear and golden.

"Blessed One, never before, not even in times long past, have I seen the Tathāgata's faculties so serene, the color of his face so completely pure, and the hue of his skin so perfectly clear and golden. Blessed One, I therefore think this: today the Tathāgata is keeping in mind the tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly

complete buddhas of the past, the future, and the present. Today the Tathāgata dwells in the abiding of a buddha, in the abiding of a victor, in the abiding of omniscience, and in the abiding of a great elephant. That is what I think."

When he had said this, the Blessed One said to the venerable Ānanda, "Excellent, Ānanda, excellent! Did the gods tell you this, or the buddhas, the blessed ones? Or do you know it in this way through your own discerning knowledge?"

When the Blessed One had said this, the venerable Ānanda said to the Blessed One, "Blessed One, the gods did not tell me this, nor did the buddhas, the blessed ones. Rather, Blessed One, through my own discernment I thought: today the Tathāgata is keeping in mind the tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly complete buddhas of the past, the future, and the present, and today the Tathāgata dwells in the abiding of a buddha, in the abiding of a victor, in the abiding of omniscience, and in the abiding of a great elephant."

When he had said this, the Blessed One said to the venerable Ānanda, "Ānanda, your reflection is vast, your discernment is excellent, and your eloquence is virtuous. Ānanda, you have set out for the benefit of many people and the happiness of many people, out of compassion for the world, and for the welfare, benefit, and happiness of the great multitude of beings, of gods and humans. That you have thought to ask the Tathāgata about this is excellent, excellent!

"Ānanda, it is just so. Even when the wisdom and vision of immeasurable, countless tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly complete buddhas are gathered together, the wisdom and vision of the Tathāgata suffers no impairment."

"Why is that? Ānanda, it is because the wisdom and vision of the Tathāgata are unobstructed. Ānanda, if the Tathāgata wished, he could remain for an eon, or a hundred eons, or a thousand eons, or a hundred thousand eons, or even longer than that, on a single meal of alms, and still the faculties of the Tathāgata would not decline. The color of his face would not change. The color of his skin would not be impaired. Why is that? Because, Ānanda, the Tathāgata has gone to the far shore of the bliss of meditative absorption.

"Ānanda, it is extremely rare for perfectly complete buddhas to appear in the world. For example, just as the udumbara flower rarely appears in the world, in the same way, Ānanda, it is extremely rare for tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly complete buddhas to appear in the world: those who seek the welfare of all

sentient beings, who seek their benefit, who are loving, and who have entered upon great compassion. Ānanda, you wish to bring the courageous teachers of the whole world to appear in the world, and for the sake of the bodhisattva great beings you have thought to ask the Tathāgata about this matter. That is the power of the Tathāgata. Therefore, Ānanda, listen well and thoroughly, and keep it in mind, and I shall explain it to you."

Ānanda replied, "So be it, Blessed One," and listened as the Blessed One had instructed. The Blessed One then spoke these words:

"Ānanda, long ago in the past, countless eons from now, even more than countless, exceedingly vast, immeasurable, inconceivable, at that time, in that age, a tathāgata, arhat, perfectly complete buddha called Dīpaṃkara appeared in the world. Ānanda, long, long before the tathāgata Dīpaṃkara, a tathāgata called Radiant appeared. Long, long before him, a tathāgata called Light Maker appeared. Long, long before him, a tathāgata called Sandalwood Fragrance appeared. Ānanda, long, long before that tathāgata Sandalwood Fragrance, a tathāgata called Like Mount Meru appeared. In the same way, a tathāgata called Moon Face appeared.

"There were the tathāgata called Stainless Face, the tathāgata called Unsullied, the tathāgata called Stainless Light, the tathāgata called Outshining the Nāgas, the tathāgata called Sun Face, the tathāgata called Melody of the King of Mountains, the tathāgata called Meru Peak, the tathāgata called Golden Light, the tathāgata called Starlight, the tathāgata called Beryl Radiance, the tathāgata called Voice of Brahmā, the tathāgata called Outshining the Moon, the tathāgata called Melody of the Sun, the tathāgata called Adorned with the Light of Scattered Flowers, the tathāgata called Glorious Heap, the tathāgata called Higher Knowledge Sporting with an Intellect like the Supreme Ocean, the tathāgata called Supreme Light, the tathāgata called Appearing as the Great King of Incense, the tathāgata called Free of Dust, Stain, and Anger, the tathāgata called Glorious Heap, the tathāgata called Giver of Jewels, the tathāgata called Higher Knowledge That Has Attained an Intellect Endowed with Great Qualities, the tathāgata called Eclipsing Sun and Moon with His Light, the tathāgata called Appearing as Refined Beryl, the tathāgata called Exalted in the Vast Intellect of the Mind Stream, the tathāgata called Higher Knowledge of the Fully Blossomed Flower, King of the Forest of Flower Garlands, the tathāgata called Source of Flowers, the tathāgata called Like the Moon in Water, the tathāgata called Destroyer of the Darkness of Ignorance, the tathāgata called Lord of the World, the

tathāgata called Parasol like Pearls and Coral, the tathāgata called Wished For, the tathāgata called King Proclaimed by the Intelligence of the Dharma, the tathāgata called King Proclaimed like a Lion, an Ocean, and a Peak, the tathāgata called Ocean, Meru, and Moon, the tathāgata called Delighting in the Roar of Brahmā's Voice, the tathāgata called Flower Arising, the tathāgata called Gainer of a Host, the tathāgata called Sun and Moon, the tathāgata called Heap of Meru, the tathāgata called Moonlight, the tathāgata called Stainless Eye, the tathāgata called Resounding Voice of the King of Mountains, the tathāgata called Flower Light, the tathāgata called Scattering a Rain of Flowers, the tathāgata called Jewel Parasol, the tathāgata called Beautifying the Road with Lotuses, the tathāgata called Sandalwood Fragrance, the tathāgata called Fragrance of Fine Incense, the tathāgata called Appearing as Jewels, the tathāgata called Encircling Rim, the tathāgata called Great Array, the tathāgata called Free of Dust and Aversion, the tathāgata called Voice of Brahmā, the tathāgata called Raining Down the Seven Precious Things, the tathāgata called Endowed with Great Qualities, the tathāgata called Anointed with Tamāla Leaves and Sandalwood Paste, the tathāgata called Higher Knowledge of Flowers, the tathāgata called Destroyer of Unknowing, the tathāgata called Matted Locks, the tathāgata called Pearl Parasol, the tathāgata called Golden Essence,

the Tathāgata called Vaiḍūryagarbha, the Tathāgata called Mahāketu, the Tathāgata called Dharmaketu, the Tathāgata called Ratnaśrī, the Tathāgata called Narendra, the Tathāgata called Lokendra, the Tathāgata called Kāruṇika, the Tathāgata called Lokasundara, the Tathāgata called Brahmaketu, the Tathāgata called Dharmamati, the Tathāgata called Siṃha, and the Tathāgata called Siṃhamati.

Ānanda, even earlier than the time before the Tathāgata Siṃhamati, there appeared in the world the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha, endowed with knowledge and conduct, the Sugata, the knower of the world, the unsurpassed guide who tames beings, the teacher of gods and humans, the Buddha, the Blessed One called Lokeśvararāja.

Ānanda, in the teaching of that Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Lokeśvararāja, there was a monk called Dharmākara. He was greatly endowed with mindfulness, endowed with intelligence, endowed with realization, endowed with wisdom, and endowed with diligence, and he was devoted to what is vast.

Ānanda, then the monk Dharmākara rose from his seat, draped his upper robe over one shoulder, and placed his right knee on the ground. He bowed with joined palms toward where the Blessed One, the Tathāgata Lokeśvararāja, was, paid homage to the Blessed One, and then praised him to his face with these verses:

Immeasurable is your light, boundless and matchless your mind;
no other light whatsoever shines beside it.
The lights of the sun, the moon, and hosts of jewels
do not blaze forth in any world.

O essence of beings, your form is without limit;
likewise, Buddha, your speech has boundless melody.
In moral discipline, concentration, wisdom, and diligence,
there is no other in this world like you.

You have found the Dharma, profound and most vast;
the mind of the supreme Buddha is like an ocean.
Yet in teaching you have no conceit;
having cast off what is base and hateful, you carry beings to the farther shore.

Just as the splendor of the supreme Buddha is boundless,
and the majesty of the Lord of Men blazes in all directions,
so I too shall become a buddha, a king of Dharma,
and set beings fully free from aging and death.

Generosity, self-control, moral discipline, patience, diligence,
meditative concentration, samādhi, and likewise supreme wisdom:
these disciplines I have truly taken up.
I shall become a buddha who protects all sentient beings.

Seeking awakening, the supreme peace beyond compare,
I shall worship all those protectors,
many hundreds of thousands of millions of buddhas,
as boundless as the sands of the Ganges.

World-systems as many as the Ganges' grains,
and the boundless fields beyond them:
to all of these I shall send forth light.
Such a power of diligence I shall undertake.

Having adorned a vast field, foremost, sublime, and supreme,
here in this conditioned realm,

the bliss of the matchless realm of nirvāṇa,
I shall purify it so that nothing equals it.

Beings who come there from the ten directions,
once arrived, will swiftly delight in happiness.
May the Buddha, the valid authority, be my witness here:
I wish to generate an unerring power of diligence.

The wise ones of the worlds of the ten directions,
whose knowledge is unobstructed, always know my mind.
Though I should go to the hell of ceaseless torment and dwell there always,
I shall never turn back from the power of my aspiration.

Ānanda, then the monk Dharmākara, having thus praised the Blessed One, the Tathāgata Lokeśvararāja, to his face with these verses, addressed him as follows: "Blessed One, I wish to fully awaken into unsurpassed, perfectly complete awakening. As I again and again generate the mind set on unsurpassed, perfectly complete awakening and make dedication, I request the Blessed One to teach me well the Dharma by which I may swiftly and fully awaken into unsurpassed, perfectly complete awakening and become in the world a tathāgata equal to the unequaled. I also request the Blessed One to explain fully to me the ways by which I shall take up the perfect array of the qualities and ornaments of a buddha field."

Ānanda, when he had made this request, the Blessed One, the Tathāgata Lokeśvararāja, spoke to the monk Dharmākara as follows: "Therefore, monk, you yourself take up the perfect array of the qualities and ornaments of a buddha field."

He replied, "Blessed One, I am not equal to that. I request the Blessed One to explain the perfect arrays of the qualities and ornaments of the buddha fields of other tathāgatas, so that by hearing of them all my own arrays may become complete."

Ānanda, then the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Lokeśvararāja, knowing the monk's intention, wishing for his aim and wishing for his benefit, compassionate, took up compassion. So that the lineage of the buddhas would not be cut off, he generated great compassion for sentient beings, and for a full ten million years he thoroughly explained the perfect arrays of the qualities and ornaments of the buddha fields of eighty-one hundred thousand koṭis of niyutas of buddhas, together with their aspects,

together with their locations, and together with the grounds from which they arose.

Then the venerable Ānanda said to the Blessed One, "Blessed One, how long was the lifespan of that Blessed One Lokeśvararāja?"

When he had asked this, the Blessed One said to the venerable Ānanda:

"Ānanda, the lifespan of that Tathāgata Lokeśvararāja was a full forty hundred thousand koṭis of niyutas of eons.

Then, Ānanda, the monk Dharmākara took up all the perfect arrays of qualities and ornaments of the buddhafields of those eighty-one hundred thousand koṭis of niyutas of buddhas, gathered into a single buddhafield. He bowed his head at the feet of the Blessed One (the Buddha), the Tathāgata Lokeśvararāja, circumambulated him, and departed from the presence of that Blessed One. For five eons he took up a perfect array of the qualities and ornaments of a buddhafield, exceedingly vast and exceedingly excellent, such as had never before arisen in any of the world systems of the ten directions. He also made exceedingly vast aspirations.

Thus, Ānanda, he took up a perfect buddhafield far more vast, far more excellent, and far more immeasurable even than the perfect fields of those eighty-one hundred thousand koṭis of niyutas of buddhas that the Blessed One, the Tathāgata Lokeśvararāja, had described. Then he went to where the Blessed One Lokeśvararāja was, and when he arrived he bowed his head at the feet of that Blessed One and said: 'Blessed One, I have taken up the perfect array of the qualities and ornaments of my buddhafield.'

Ānanda, when he had said this, the Tathāgata Lokeśvararāja spoke to the monk Dharmākara: 'Then speak, monk, for the Tathāgata too will rejoice. This is the time. Gladden the assembly! Bring forth delight! Roar the lion's roar! When they hear it, bodhisattva great beings, now and in the future, will take up such a perfect buddhafield as this, a ground for aspirations, and will bring it to completion.'

Then, Ānanda, the monk Dharmākara said to that Blessed One: 'Therefore, may the Blessed One please listen to my special aspirations, through which, when I have fully awakened to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, that buddhafield will come to possess an inconceivable array of qualities and ornaments.

Blessed One, if in that buddhafield of mine there should be hells, the animal realm, the domain of hungry ghosts, or the realm of the asuras, then for as long as that is so, I shall not fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening.

Blessed One, unless the beings born in that buddhafield of mine never fall, after dying and passing on from there, into the hells, the animal realm, the domain of hungry ghosts, or the realm of the asuras, until then I shall not fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening.

Blessed One, unless all the beings born in that buddhafield of mine are of a single color, the color of gold, until then I shall not fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening.

Blessed One, if in that buddhafield of mine gods and humans should be distinct, rather than being reckoned as "gods and humans" only by name and designation, as a mere expression of conventional usage, then for as long as that is so, I shall not fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening.

Blessed One, unless all the beings born in that buddhafield of mine reach the supreme perfection of mastery over miraculous power, so that in even a single instant of mind they can cross a hundred thousand koṭis of niyutas of buddhafields, until then I shall not fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening.

Blessed One, unless all the beings born in that buddhafield of mine remember their past lives, recollecting at least a hundred thousand koṭis of niyutas of eons, until then I shall not fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening.

Blessed One, unless all the beings born in that buddhafield of mine attain the divine eye that sees at least a hundred thousand koṭis of niyutas of world systems, until then I shall not fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening.

Blessed One, unless all the beings born in that buddhafield of mine attain the divine ear that hears the Dharma simultaneously in at least a hundred thousand koṭis of niyutas of buddhafields, until then I shall not fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening.

Blessed One, unless all the beings born in that buddhafield of mine become skilled in knowing the minds of others, fully knowing the mental activity of the

beings belonging to at least a hundred thousand koṭis of niyutas of buddhafields, until then I shall not fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening.

Blessed One, if all the beings born in that buddhafield of mine should give rise to even the slightest perception of grasping at their own bodies, then for that long I shall not fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening.

"Blessed One, if all the beings born in that buddhafield of mine are not, until their great final nirvāṇa, firmly settled in the true state, then for as long as that is so, I shall not fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening.

"Blessed One, if, when I have fully awakened to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening, any being in that buddhafield could arrive at a count of the number of śrāvakas, even if every being in the great trichiliocosm became a pratyekabuddha and they counted for a hundred thousand koṭis of niyutas of eons and arrived at a number, then for as long as that is so, I shall not fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening.

"Blessed One, if, when I have fully awakened to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening, my light in that buddhafield should have a measurable extent, even one measured as a hundred thousand koṭis of niyutas of buddhafields, then for as long as that is so, I shall not fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening.

"Blessed One, if, when I have fully awakened to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening, the lifespan of the beings in that buddhafield should have a limit, except by the power of their own aspirations, then for as long as that is so, I shall not fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening.

"Blessed One, if, when I have attained awakening, my lifespan should come to an end, even after being counted as a hundred thousand koṭis of niyutas of eons, then for as long as that is so, I shall not fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening.

"Blessed One, if, when I have attained awakening, the beings in that buddhafield should have even the word for non-virtue, then for as long as that is so, I shall not fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening.

"Blessed One, if, when I have attained awakening, the countless, immeasurable buddhas, the blessed ones, in immeasurable buddhafields do not proclaim my name, do not speak my praise, do not speak my eulogy, and do not speak of my renown, then for as long as that is so, I shall not fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening.

"Blessed One, if, when I have attained awakening, there are beings in other world systems who have generated the mind set on unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening, who hear my name, whose minds become filled with faith, and who keep me in mind, and if, when the time of their death draws near, I do not stand before them, surrounded and preceded by a saṅgha of monks, so that they abide with undistracted minds, then for as long as that is so, I shall not fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening.

"Blessed One, if, when I have attained awakening, there are beings in countless, immeasurable buddhafields who hear my name, turn their minds toward being born in that buddhafield, and also dedicate their roots of virtue to that end, and if they are not born in that buddhafield even by generating that thought just ten times, excepting only those beings who have committed the acts of immediate retribution and those obscured by the obscuration of rejecting the true Dharma, then for as long as that is so, I shall not fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening.

"Blessed One, if, when I have attained awakening, all the beings born in that buddhafield are not endowed with the thirty-two major marks of a great being, then for as long as that is so, I shall not fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening.

"Blessed One, if, when I have attained awakening, the beings born in that buddhafield are not all bound to just one more birth before unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening, then for as long as that is so, I shall not fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening. I except only the special aspirations of those bodhisattva great beings who have donned the great armor; who have donned armor for the sake of all the world; who strive for the welfare of all the world; who are intent on bringing all the world to final nirvāṇa; who wish to practice the conduct of a bodhisattva in all world systems; who wish to serve all the buddhas; who wish to establish beings as numerous as the sands of the river Ganges in unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening; who are, moreover, turned toward ever higher conduct; and who have gone forth through the conduct of Samantabhadra.

"Blessed One, if, when I have attained awakening, all the beings born in that buddhafield do not, within a single morning, go to other buddhafields and, through the power of the Buddha, honor many hundreds of buddhas, many thousands of buddhas, many hundreds of thousands of buddhas, many koṭis of buddhas, up to many hundreds of thousands of koṭis of niyutas of buddhas, with every provision for their comfort, then for as long as that is so, I shall not fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening.

Blessed One, when I attain awakening, the bodhisattvas in that buddhafield may wish for gold, silver, jewels, pearls, beryl, conch, crystal, coral, quartz, agate, emerald, red pearls, or anything of that sort, or for all kinds of precious things, or for flowers, perfumes, garlands, ointments, incense, powders, cloth, parasols, victory banners, pennants, every kind of lamp, song, dance, and the sound of music, whatever kinds of things they wish for in order to cultivate roots of virtue. As long as such things do not appear for them the very moment they think of them, I will not fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening.

Blessed One, when I attain awakening, as long as all the beings born in that buddhafield do not speak in Dharma discourse endowed with omniscience, I will not fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening.

Blessed One, when I attain awakening, the bodhisattvas in that buddhafield may think, "While remaining in this world system, let us honor, revere, serve, and worship the buddhas, the blessed ones, in countless and immeasurable buddhafields with rains of robes, food, bedding, medicine for the sick, requisites, flowers, incense, perfumes, garlands, ointments, powders, robes, parasols, victory banners, pennants, song, dance, music, and jewels of every kind." As long as those buddhas, the blessed ones, do not, out of compassion, accept those offerings the very moment those bodhisattvas give rise to that thought, I will not fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening.

Blessed One, when I attain awakening, as long as all the beings born in that buddhafield do not gain the strength of Nārāyaṇa, bodies as hard as vajra, and great power, I will not fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening.

Blessed One, when I attain awakening, should any being in that buddhafield gaze with the divine eye toward the furthest reach of the colors of its adornments, as long as such a being does not perceive their diverse colors,

thinking, "Such is the splendor of this buddhafield, such is its color, such is its wealth," I will not fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening.

Blessed One, when I attain awakening, as long as even the bodhisattva with the fewest roots of virtue among all those in that buddhafield does not see the tree of awakening as some one thousand six hundred leagues high, I will not fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening.

Blessed One, when I attain awakening, as long as all the bodhisattvas in that buddhafield who receive the scriptures and recite them do not attain the analytical knowledges, I will not fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening.

Blessed One, when I attain awakening, as long as all the beings born in that buddhafield do not attain wisdom and boundless eloquence, I will not fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening.

Blessed One, when I attain awakening, as long as that buddhafield is not so luminous that in it, everywhere, immeasurable, countless, inconceivable, incomparable, and measureless buddhafields appear on all sides, just as the disc of one's face appears in the disc of a well-polished mirror, I will not fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening.

Blessed One, when I attain awakening, as long as in that buddhafield, from the surface of the ground up to the sky, fine kinds of incense far surpassing the realms of gods and humans, worthy of the tathāgatas and bodhisattvas, a richly fragrant incense, are not constantly burned in hundreds of thousands of vessels made of various precious substances, I will not fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening.

Blessed One, when I attain awakening, as long as in that buddhafield rains of richly fragrant flowers of many kinds do not constantly fall, and clouds of delightful musical melodies do not constantly resound, I will not fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening.

Blessed One, when I attain awakening, as long as all the beings in countless, inconceivable, and incomparable world systems who are illuminated by my light do not come to possess a happiness far surpassing that of gods and humans, I will not fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening.

Blessed One, when I attain awakening, as long as the bodhisattvas in immeasurable, countless, inconceivable, incomparable, and measureless buddhafields everywhere who hear my name do not, through the root of virtue arising the moment they hear it, attain dhāraṇī from their next life onward until they reach the seat of awakening, I will not fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening.

Blessed One, if, when I have attained awakening, there should be women in the countless, inconceivable, incomparable and immeasurable buddhafields everywhere who hear my name, give rise to clear faith, generate the mind set on awakening and come to despise the female body, and yet, after their lives have ended, take a woman's body a second time, then for as long as that is so, I will not fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening.

Blessed One, if, when I have attained awakening, there should be sentient beings in the immeasurable, countless, inconceivable, incomparable and limitless buddhafields who hear my name, and yet, through merely hearing that name, do not practice the pure life until they reach the seat of awakening, then for as long as that is so, I will not fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening.

Blessed One, if, when I have attained awakening, there should be sentient beings in the immeasurable, countless, inconceivable, incomparable and limitless buddhafields throughout the ten directions who hear my name and pay homage by prostrating with the five limbs, and yet, while they practice the conduct of a bodhisattva, they are not honored by the world with its gods, then for as long as that is so, I will not fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening.

Blessed One, if, when I have attained awakening, any bodhisattva in that buddhafield should have to do the work of washing, drying, sewing or dyeing robes, and if it does not come about, as I wish, that the very moment they think of it they are clothed in new and precious robes, properly stitched and of fine quality, as permitted by the Tathāgata, then for as long as that is so, I will not fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening.

Blessed One, if, when I have attained awakening, the sentient beings in that buddhafield should not, as soon as they are born, attain a bliss like that of a monk who is an arhat, free of all torment, absorbed in the third meditative concentration, then for as long as that is so, I will not fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening.

Blessed One, if, when I have attained awakening, the bodhisattvas born in that buddhafield should not behold, in the various jewel trees, whatever kinds of arrays of the buddhafield's ornaments of good qualities they wish for, then for as long as that is so, I will not fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening.

Blessed One, if, when I have attained awakening, bodhisattvas born in other buddhafields should hear my name and yet not obtain faculties without any deficiency, then for as long as that is so, I will not fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening.

Blessed One, if, when I have attained awakening, the bodhisattvas dwelling in other buddhafields should not, the moment they hear my name, attain the samādhi called Thoroughly Discerning, and if those bodhisattvas, abiding in that samādhi, should not, within the passing of a single instant, see immeasurable, countless, inconceivable, incomparable and limitless buddhas, blessed ones, with that samādhi remaining unbroken in between, then for as long as that is so, I will not fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening.

Blessed One, if, when I have attained awakening, sentient beings who hear my name should not, through the root of virtue arising from that very hearing, obtain birth in noble families until they reach awakening, then for as long as that is so, I will not fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening.

Blessed One, if, when I have attained awakening, the bodhisattvas in buddhafields other than this who hear my name should not, through the root of virtue arising from that very hearing, all meet, until they reach awakening, with the roots of virtue that bring joy and supreme joy in the conduct of a bodhisattva, then for as long as that is so, I will not fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening.

Blessed One, if, when I have attained awakening, the bodhisattvas in world systems other than this should not, the moment they hear my name, attain the samādhi called Following All, and if those bodhisattvas, abiding in that samādhi, should not, within the passing of a single instant, pay honor to countless, immeasurable, inconceivable, incomparable and limitless buddhas, blessed ones, with that samādhi remaining unbroken until they reach the seat of awakening, then for as long as that is so, I will not fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening.

Blessed One, if, when I have attained awakening, the sentient beings born in that buddhafield should not hear whatever kind of Dharma teaching they wish to hear the very moment they think of it, then for as long as that is so, I will not fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening.

Blessed One, if, when I have attained awakening, the bodhisattvas in other buddhafields who hear my name should not, the very moment they hear my name, become irreversible from unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening, then for as long as that is so, I will not fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening.

"Blessed One, when I have attained awakening, there may be bodhisattvas in other buddha fields who hear my name. If, immediately on hearing it, they do not attain the first, second, and third forbearances, and do not become irreversible from the qualities of a buddha, then for as long as that is so, I will not fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening."

Ānanda, the monk Dharmākara set forth these special aspirations. Then, through the power of the Buddha, he spoke these verses:

"If, when I attain awakening, my supreme aspirations
Do not prove to be this distinguished and exalted,
Let me not become the possessor of the ten powers, the peerless one worthy of offerings,
The lion among humans, the very heart of beings.

If I do not bring forth a field such as that,
If I do not bestow great wealth on the many poor,
And if I do not bring happiness to people who suffer,
Let me not become the king of humans, the precious jewel.

When I draw near to the seat of awakening,
If my name is not proclaimed
Through the many vast fields of the ten directions, without end,
Let me not become the protector of the world who has gained the powers.

While I truly seek the peerless peace of awakening,
If my mindfulness, intelligence, and realization should decline,
And if I should indulge in the pleasures of the senses,
Let me not become the teacher of the world who has gained the powers.

With light most vast, peerless, and boundless,
I, the protector, shall pervade all buddha fields in the directions and the

intermediate directions.
I shall fully pacify all attachment, aversion, and delusion,
And quench the fires of beings fallen into the hells.

Opening an eye most beautiful and wide,
I shall dispel the dense darkness of all humankind.
Removing every state that lacks leisure, leaving none,
I shall set them on the path to the higher realms of boundless splendor.

Having practiced my former conduct in perfect purity,
The light of sun and moon in the sky will not blaze,
And the lights of heaped jewels, of fire, and of the gods
Will all be outshone by the light of the lion among humans.

Become the supreme person, a treasure for those who suffer,
With no form like mine in any direction or intermediate direction,
Having brought hundreds of thousands of virtues to perfection,
I shall sit in the assembly and roar the lion's roar of a buddha.

Having shown reverence to the self-arisen victors of the past,
Having practiced countless millions of disciplines and austerities,
And having sought the sublime and supreme heap of wisdom,
I shall perfect the power of aspiration and become the heart of beings.

Just as the Blessed One, whose wisdom's vision is free of attachment,
The lord of humans who fully knows the three kinds of conditioned things,
So may I too become peerless, wise, and worthy of offerings,
The supreme guide of humans among humans.

Once I, a lord of humans, have fully attained awakening,
If these aspirations are to be fulfilled,
Let this thousandfold world system quake,
And let the hosts of gods rain flowers from the sky!"

The earth quaked, and a rain of flowers fell.
From the sky came the sound of cymbals,
And powder of beautiful divine sandalwood
Was scattered all around: he will become a buddha in the world.

The second section.

Ānanda, the monk Dharmākara, the bodhisattva great being, was endowed with such excellent aspirations. Ānanda, bodhisattvas endowed with excellent aspirations such as these are few. Aspirations of this kind rarely appear in the

world. They are few, but not wholly absent.

Ānanda, the monk Dharmākara set forth these special aspirations before the Blessed One, the Tathāgata Lokeśvararāja, in the presence of the world with its gods, māras, and Brahmās, its population of ascetics and brahmins, its gods, humans, and asuras. He then came to abide in practice exactly as it truly is, and he accomplished such purity of a buddha field, such greatness of a buddha field, and such vastness of a buddha field. He practiced the conduct of a bodhisattva for countless hundreds of thousands of koṭis of niyutas of years, innumerable, inconceivable, incomparable, immeasurable, limitless, inexpressible. Throughout that time he never once engaged in conceptual thoughts of desire, malice, or harm. Never once did he give rise to perceptions of desire, malice, or harm. Never once did he give rise to perceptions of forms, sounds, smells, tastes, or tangible objects.

That youth was gentle and pleasant to be with. He was accepting by nature, easy to satisfy, and easy to support. He had few desires and was content, fully secluded, free of aversion, and free of bewilderment. He was upright and never base, without guile and without deceit, of good disposition, gentle, and pleasant in speech. He was ever diligent and never gave up his diligence in seeking out the pure qualities. He accomplished great aspirations for the sake of all sentient beings.

He was reverent toward the Buddha, the Dharma, and the Saṅgha, toward his teachers, his preceptors, and his spiritual friends. He was ever armored for the conduct of a bodhisattva. Upright, gentle, without pretense or flattery, and endowed with good qualities, he led the way in bringing all sentient beings to take up every virtuous quality. He dwelt in the abiding of emptiness, signlessness, wishlessness, non-formation, non-arising, and non-cessation. He was without pride and kept his speech well guarded.

While he was practicing the conduct of a bodhisattva, he gave up every kind of verbal action that would harm himself, others, or both, and he devoted himself to those verbal actions that would benefit himself, others, and both. Being vigilant in this way, whenever he entered villages, towns, market towns, provinces, or royal palaces, he never felt attachment or aversion toward forms, sounds, smells, tastes, tangible objects, or mental phenomena. While practicing the conduct of a bodhisattva, he himself practiced the perfection of generosity, and he also led others to take it up properly. He himself practiced the perfections of moral discipline, patience, diligence, meditative

concentration, and wisdom, and he also led others to take them up properly. He accomplished roots of virtue of such a kind that, because he possessed them, wherever he was born, many hundreds of thousands of billions of trillions of treasures would spring forth from the ground.

While practicing the conduct of a bodhisattva, he established in unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening countless, immeasurable hundreds of thousands of billions of trillions of sentient beings, so many that it would not be easy to finish recounting them in words. He revered, honored, and served just as many countless, immeasurable blessed buddhas, and made offerings to them of robes, food, bedding, medicines for the sick, and other requisites, together with everything that makes for living in comfort and ease. The sentient beings he brought to maturity, and those he established as merchants, householders, and ministers, and in royal and brahmin families as stately as great sāla trees, could likewise not easily be finished by telling them in words. In the same way, he established beings in lordship over Jambudvīpa, in the status of a universal monarch (cakravartin), of a world guardian, of Śakra (Indra), of Suyāma, of Santuṣita, of Sunirmita, of Vaśavartin, of a king of the gods, and of Mahābrahmā. The countless, immeasurable blessed buddhas whom he revered, honored, served, and worshipped, and then requested to turn the wheel of Dharma, also could not easily be finished by describing them in words.

While he was practicing the conduct of a bodhisattva, for immeasurable, countless, inconceivable, incomparable, unfathomable, limitless, and inexpressible hundreds of thousands of billions of trillions of eons, a most delightful fragrance of sandalwood, far surpassing that of the gods, came from his mouth, and the fragrance of utpala flowers came from every pore of his body. In all the worlds he was handsome, beautiful, and pleasing to behold, possessed of a supreme, excellent, and radiant complexion, his body well adorned with the excellent major and minor marks. All jewel ornaments, all manifested garments and robes, all manifested flowers, incense, fumigants, garlands, ointments, parasols, victory banners, and pennants, and all manifested instrumental music and song came forth from every pore of his body and from his two hands. And all manifested food, drink, solid food, soft food, things to lick, and delicious flavors, and all manifested enjoyments and articles of use, streamed and flowed forth from his two hands. Such was the virtue that he accomplished. Ānanda, in this way the monk Dharmākara, formerly, while practicing the conduct of a bodhisattva, reached the perfection

of mastery over all requisites.

When the Blessed One had said this, the venerable Ānanda said to the Blessed One, "Blessed One, how is it? Has the bodhisattva, the great being Dharmākara, fully awakened to unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening and passed into complete nirvāṇa? Or has he not yet fully awakened? Or has he fully awakened at the present time, and does he now dwell, live, and abide, teaching the Dharma?"

The Blessed One said, "Ānanda, that Tathāgata is neither past nor future. That Tathāgata has fully awakened to unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening and now dwells, lives, and abides, teaching the Dharma. A hundred thousand billion trillion buddhafields to the west of here, in the world system Sukhāvatī, is the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha called Amitābha. Surrounded and preceded by immeasurable bodhisattva great beings and infinite śrāvakas, he possesses the infinite perfection of a buddhafield. His light is immeasurable. It is not easy to grasp the extent of its limit, saying, 'It abides pervading this many buddhafields, a hundred such buddhafields, a thousand such buddhafields, a hundred thousand such buddhafields, ten million such buddhafields, a billion such buddhafields, ten billion such buddhafields, a trillion such buddhafields, a hundred thousand billion trillion such buddhafields.' Yet, Ānanda, to put it briefly, the light of the Blessed One Amitābha constantly pervades as many hundred thousand billion trillion buddhafields in the east as there are grains of sand in the river Ganges.

Likewise, in each of the other directions, south, west, north, below, above, and the intermediate directions, buddhafields as numerous as the sands of hundreds of thousands of koṭis of nayutas of Ganges Rivers are constantly pervaded by the light of that Blessed One, the Tathāgata Amitābha. The only exceptions are those places where, by the blessing of the past aspirations of the buddhas, the blessed ones, there abides a light that pervades one fathom, two fathoms, three, four, five, ten, twenty, thirty, forty, or fifty fathoms, a light of ten yojanas, a light of a hundred yojanas, a light of a thousand yojanas, a light of a hundred thousand yojanas, up to a light of many hundreds of thousands of koṭis of nayutas of yojanas, pervading world systems.

Ānanda, there is no example by which one could frame a simile that measures the light of that Blessed One, the Tathāgata Amitābha. Ānanda, for this reason that Tathāgata is called Amitābha. He is called Immeasurable Light, Immeasurable Radiance, Unbounded Light, Unattached Light, Unobstructed

Light, Ever-Radiating Light, Light of Divine Jewels, Light of the King of Unobstructed Rays, Endearing Light, Gladdening Light, Supremely Gladdening Light, Satisfying Light, Captivating Light, Binding Light, Inconceivable Light, Incomparable Light, Light Outshining Lords of Humans and Lords of Gods, Light Outshining and Eclipsing the Sun and Moon, and Light Outshining and Eclipsing the World Guardians, Śakra (Indra), Brahmā, the gods of the Pure Abodes, Maheśvara (Śiva), and all the gods. In short, he is called the Perfection of All Lights.

That light of his is stainless and most vast. It brings bliss to the body and gladdens the mind. For gods, asuras, nāgas, yakṣas, gandharvas, garuḍas, mahoragas, kinnaras, humans, and nonhumans it produces joy, supreme joy, and happiness. For sentient beings of virtuous intent it brings virtue, lightness, understanding, skill, intelligence, and supreme joy.

Ānanda, in this way, even if endless, boundless other buddhafields were completely filled with tathāgatas, and for an eon they made it their task to proclaim the names of that Tathāgata Amitābha, and spoke of his perfect light, they still could not reach the end of the teaching of his names or of the qualities of his perfect light, and yet the fearless eloquence of those tathāgatas would never be interrupted. And why is that? Ānanda, it is because the wealth of qualities of the light of that Blessed One Amitābha, and the wisdom and unsurpassed eloquence of the Tathāgata, these two, are countless, immeasurable, inconceivable, and endless.

Ānanda, the Saṅgha of śrāvakas of that Tathāgata Amitābha is immeasurable. It is not easy to take its measure by saying, "There are this many koṭis of śrāvakas," or "There are this many hundreds of koṭis of śrāvakas," or "There are this many thousands of koṭis of śrāvakas," or "There are this many hundreds of thousands of koṭis of śrāvakas," or "this many bimbaras," or "this many kaṅkaras," or "this many nayutas," or "this many trillions," or "this many akṣobhyas," or "this many vivāhas," or "this many flowing streams," or "this many victories," or "this many immeasurables," or "this many countless numbers," or "this many incalculables," or "this many incomparables," or "this many inconceivables."

Ānanda, suppose, for example, that the monk Mahāmaudgalyāyana, who has gained mastery over miraculous powers, could, if he wished, count in a single day and night all the stars there are in a great trichiliocosm, and suppose there were hundreds of thousands of koṭis of nayutas of monks endowed with

miraculous powers of that kind. If they did nothing else for hundreds of thousands of koṭis of nayutas of years but count the first assembly of śrāvakas of the Tathāgata Amitābha, they would not count even a hundredth part of it. They would not count even a thousandth, nor a hundred-thousandth, nor any fraction, nor any portion fit for comparison or approximation.

Ānanda, suppose, for example, that from the great ocean, eighty-four thousand yojanas deep and immeasurable in extent, some person took up a single drop of water with the tip of a hair split into a hundred strands. Ānanda, what do you think of that? Which of the two is greater: the single drop of water taken up with the tip of a hair split into a hundred strands, or the mass of water remaining in the great ocean?

Ānanda replied, "Blessed One, even a thousand yojanas is little compared with the great ocean, so what need is there to speak of a single drop of water taken up with the tip of a hair split into a hundred strands?"

The Blessed One said, "Ānanda, like that single drop of water is the number that monks like Maudgalyāyana would arrive at by counting the first assembly of śrāvakas of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata Amitābha, for hundreds of thousands of koṭis of nayutas of years, saying, 'There are this many.' What is like the mass of water remaining in the great ocean should be regarded as beyond the reach of number. What need, then, to speak of the second and third assemblies of śrāvakas? Thus the Saṅgha of śrāvakas of that Blessed One is endless and boundless. It falls within the number called 'immeasurable.'"

Ānanda, the lifespan of that Blessed One, the Tathāgata Amitābha, is also immeasurable. It is not easy to determine the measure of that lifespan by saying, "It is so many eons," or "It is so many hundreds of eons," or "It is so many thousands of eons," or "It is so many hundreds of thousands of eons," or "It is so many koṭis of eons," or "It is so many hundreds of koṭis of eons," or "It is so many thousands of koṭis of eons," or "It is so many hundreds of thousands of koṭis of eons," and so on, up to "It is so many hundreds of thousands of koṭis of niyutas of eons." Ānanda, the measure of the life of that Blessed One, the Tathāgata Amitābha, is immeasurable in this way, and that is why that Tathāgata is called Amitāyus.

Ānanda, since that Blessed One, the Tathāgata Amitābha, fully awakened into unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening, ten eons have passed, eons of the kind that are now counted and designated as eons in this world system.

Ānanda, the world system of the Blessed One Amitābha, called Sukhāvatī, is prosperous, happy, with abundant harvests, delightful, and filled with many gods and humans. Ānanda, in that world system there are no hell beings. There is no animal birth. There is no realm of hungry ghosts. There is no class of asuras. There is no birth in conditions lacking the freedom to practice. The jewels that appear in the world system Sukhāvatī are not found in use in this world.

Ānanda, that world system Sukhāvatī is pervaded by the exquisitely sweet fragrance of many kinds of incense. It abounds in many kinds of flowers and fruits. It is beautifully adorned with jewel trees. It is frequented by flocks of many kinds of birds with lovely voices, emanated by the Tathāgata.

Ānanda, those jewel trees have different colors, many colors, many hundreds of thousands of colors. Ānanda, there are jewel trees there with the color of gold and made of gold. There are some with the color of silver and made of silver. There are some with the color of beryl and made of beryl. There are some with the color of crystal and made of crystal. There are some with the color of coral and made of coral. There are some with the color of red pearl and made of red pearl. There are some with the color of emerald and made of emerald.

Some are made of two kinds of jewels: gold and silver. There are also some made of three kinds of jewels: gold, silver and beryl. There are also some made of four kinds of jewels: gold, silver, beryl and crystal. There are also some made of five kinds of jewels: gold, silver, beryl, crystal and coral. There are also some made of six kinds of jewels: gold, silver, beryl, crystal, coral and red pearl. There are also some made of seven kinds of jewels: gold, silver, beryl, crystal, coral, red pearl and emerald.

Ānanda, there, the roots, trunks, branches, leaves, petals and flowers of the golden trees are made of gold, while their fruits are made of silver. The roots, trunks, branches, leaves, petals and flowers of the silver trees are made of silver, while their fruits are made of beryl. The roots, trunks, branches, leaves, petals and flowers of the beryl trees are made of beryl, while their fruits are made of crystal. The roots, trunks, branches, leaves, petals and flowers of the crystal trees are made of crystal, while their fruits are made of coral. The roots, trunks, branches, leaves, petals and flowers of the coral trees are made of coral, while their fruits are made of red pearl. The roots, trunks, branches, leaves, petals and flowers of the red pearl trees are made of red pearl, while

their fruits are made of emerald. The roots, trunks, branches, leaves, petals and flowers of the emerald trees are made of emerald, while their fruits are made of gold.

Ānanda, of some trees the roots are made of gold, the trunks of silver, the branches of beryl, the leaves of crystal, the petals of coral, the flowers of red pearl, and the fruits of emerald.

Ānanda, of some trees the roots are made of silver, the trunks of beryl, the branches of crystal, the leaves of coral, the petals of red pearl, the flowers of emerald, and the fruits of gold.

Ānanda, of some trees the roots are made of beryl, the trunks of crystal, the branches of coral, the leaves of red pearl, the petals of emerald, the flowers of gold, and the fruits of silver.

Ānanda, of some trees the roots are made of crystal, the trunks of coral, the branches of red pearl, the leaves of emerald, the petals of gold, the flowers of silver, and the fruits of beryl.

Ānanda, of some trees the roots are made of coral, the trunks of red pearl, the branches of emerald, the leaves of gold, the petals of silver, the flowers of beryl, and the fruits of crystal.

"Ānanda, some trees have roots of red pearl, trunks of emerald, branches of gold, foliage of silver, petals of beryl, flowers of crystal, and fruits of agate. Ānanda, some trees have roots of emerald, trunks of gold, branches of silver, foliage of beryl, petals of crystal, flowers of agate, and fruits of red pearl. Ānanda, some trees have roots made of the seven precious substances. Their trunks too are made of the seven precious substances, and so are their branches, their foliage, their petals, their flowers, and their fruits.

"Ānanda, the roots, trunks, branches, foliage, petals, flowers, and fruits of all these trees are soft, pleasant to the touch, and fragrant. When the wind stirs them, a sweet and delightful sound comes from them, pleasant and harmonious, and one never tires of hearing it.

"Ānanda, that buddhafield is filled with trees of this kind, made of the seven precious substances. At its edges it is encircled by plantain trees of the seven precious substances and by rows of jeweled palm trees. All of it is covered with nets of gold, and everywhere it is covered with lotuses of the seven precious substances. There are lotuses there half a yojana across, and some a full yojana across. There are some one, two, three, four, and five yojanas across,

and some as large as ten yojanas. From every one of these jeweled lotuses there come thirty-six thousand koṭis of rays of light. From the tip of every ray there come thirty-six thousand koṭis of buddha bodies, golden in color and bearing the thirty-two marks of a great being. They go to countless, immeasurable world systems in the east and teach the Dharma to sentient beings. In the same way they go to countless, immeasurable, distinct world systems in the south, the west, the north, below, above, and in the intermediate directions, and teach the Dharma to sentient beings.

"Ānanda, in that buddhafield there are no black mountains at all. All its mountains are nothing but mountains of jewels. There is no Sumeru, king of mountains, no Cakravāḍa range, no Mahācakravāḍa, king of mountains, and there are no great oceans. That buddhafield is level everywhere, delightful and even as the palm of the hand, and its ground is adorned with jewels of every kind."

When he had said this, the venerable Ānanda said to the Blessed One, "Blessed One, the gods of the realm of the Four Great Kings dwell on the slopes of Sumeru, and the gods of the Heaven of the Thirty-Three dwell on its summit. Where, then, do they dwell there?"

The Blessed One said, "Ānanda, what do you think? Here, where do the gods above Sumeru, king of mountains, dwell: the Yāma gods, the Tuṣita, the Nirmāṇarati, the Paranirmitavaśavartin, the Brahmakāyika, the Brahmapurohita, and the gods from Mahābrahmā up to Akaniṣṭha?"

Ānanda replied, "Blessed One, the ripening of karma and the formation of karma are inconceivable."

The Blessed One said, "Ānanda, the inconceivable ripening of karma and formation of karma can be fathomed. But the inconceivable virtue, miraculous power, and blessing of the buddhas, the blessed ones, no one can fathom, measure, or conceive. In other words, it is classed as the inconceivable domain of the buddhas. Thus the inconceivable merit of the merit that beings have made and the roots of virtue they have generated, and their wisdom, miraculous power, and prosperity, arise in that buddhafield."

Ānanda said, "Blessed One, I have no doubt, hesitation, or uncertainty about this. I ask the Tathāgata about this matter in order to dispel the doubts, hesitation, and uncertainty of sentient beings in the future."

The Blessed One said, "Excellent, Ānanda, excellent! That is just what you should do. Ānanda, in that world system Sukhāvatī, rivers of many kinds flow. There are great rivers there a yojana wide, and some ten, twenty, thirty, forty, up to fifty yojanas wide, and some as much as a hundred thousand yojanas wide, and twelve yojanas deep. All these rivers flow with water of many most fragrant scents, and they flow along with masses of scattered jewel flowers. They are also filled with many different sweet sounds.

"Ānanda, from these great rivers there comes a delightful sound surpassing that of music played by skilled musicians with heavenly songs of a hundred thousand koṭis of parts. The sound that comes from these great rivers is profound, comprehensible, intelligible, not false, pleasing to the ear, touching the heart, gladdening, sweet, delightful, never tiring to hear, pleasant, and harmonious, a sound that says, 'impermanent,' 'peace,' and 'no-self,' and is pleasant to hear. It resounds in the ear faculties of those beings.

"Ānanda, both banks of these great rivers are lined with jeweled fragrant trees, from which hang branches, leaves, flowers, and clusters of blossoms of many kinds. When those beings there who wish to enjoy untainted heavenly delight and play on the banks of these rivers enter the rivers, the water, if they wish, comes only up to their ankles.

If they wish, the water stays knee-deep; if they wish, waist-deep; if they wish, neck-deep; and divine delights also arise. Those beings there who wish, "May the water be cool," find it cool. Those who wish, "May it be warm," find it warm. Those who wish, "May it be both cool and warm," find that water both cool and warm, and it is pleasant for them.

Those great rivers flow full of water scented with the leaves of the divine tamāla tree, with aloeswood, with kālānusārin, with tagara, with uragasāra sandalwood, and with the finest incense. They are covered with divine flowers: blue lotuses, lotuses, white water lilies, white lotuses, and other flowers of exquisite fragrance. In their rippling waters are geese, swans, cranes, ruddy shelducks, kāraṇḍava ducks, parrots, mynas, cuckoos, kuṇāla birds, kalaviṅka birds, peacocks and others, all with pleasing voices. They are frequented by flocks of birds emanated by the Tathāgata and beautified by swans and kings of swans. Their fords are easy to enter, they are free of mud, and they are strewn with golden sand.

There, whenever those beings wish, "May such thoughts of ours be fulfilled," at that time such thoughts of theirs are fulfilled in accordance with the Dharma.

Ānanda, the pleasing sound that comes from that water makes itself understood to the entire assembly in that buddha field. Those beings seated on the riverbanks who wish, "May this sound not reach our ears," find that it does not reach their divine ear faculty. Whoever wishes to hear a sound of whatever kind hears a pleasing sound of just that kind: namely, the sound of the Buddha, the sound of the Dharma, the sound of the Saṅgha, the sound of the perfections, the sound of the grounds, the sound of the powers, the sound of the fearlessnesses, the sound of the unshared qualities of a buddha, the sound of the superknowledges, the sound of the specific knowledges; the sound of emptiness, of signlessness, of wishlessness, of the unconditioned, of the unborn, of the unarisen, of nonentity, and of noncessation; the sound of peace, of utter peace, and of complete pacification; the sound of great loving-kindness, great compassion, great joy, and great equanimity; and the sounds of acceptance that phenomena are unborn and of attaining the ground of empowerment. Having heard such sounds, one obtains joy and vast, supreme delight. There arise sounds connected with solitude, with freedom from attachment, with peace, with cessation, with the Dharma, and with the roots of virtue that bring awakening to completion.

Ānanda, in the world Sukhāvatī, the Land of Bliss, there is not even the name of non-virtue. There is no sound of obscurations at all. There is no sound of the lower realms, the bad destinies, or the states of downfall at all. There is no sound of suffering at all. Ānanda, since there is not even the sound of a feeling that is neither painful nor pleasant, how could there be suffering or the sound of suffering? Ānanda, this is, in brief, the account by which it is called the world Sukhāvatī, but it is not the full account. Ānanda, were it given at length, even if one were to recount the causes of happiness in the world Sukhāvatī for an eon or for more than an eon, until one was exhausted, one could not reach the end of those causes of happiness.

Ānanda, all the beings who have been born, are being born, and will be born in that world Sukhāvatī possess form, complexion, strength, power, stature, mastery, accumulated merit, and the superknowledges; such kinds of enjoyment of clothing, ornaments, parks, palaces, and multistoried houses; such kinds of enjoyment of forms, sounds, smells, tastes, and tangible objects; and all such kinds of wealth and enjoyment. They are like the gods of the Paranirmitavaśavartin heaven, the gods who control the emanations of others.

Ānanda, the beings of the world Sukhāvatī do not eat coarse food taken in morsels. Whatever kind of food they wish for, they perceive it as already

present, and their bodies are satisfied and their forms are satisfied. Nor do they put it into their bodies. Once their bodies are satisfied, whatever kind of incense they wish for, the entire buddha field becomes perfumed with just such kinds of divine incense. There, for anyone who does not wish to smell that scent, not even the slightest perception of fragrance or its perfume arises. In the same way, whatever kinds of incense, garlands, ointments, powders, parasols, banners, flags, and music they wish for, the entire buddha field becomes pervaded by just such things. Whatever garments they wish for, of many hundreds of thousands of different colors, the entire buddha field becomes pervaded by just such precious garments, and they know themselves to be clothed in them.

As for ornaments for the head, ornaments for the ears, and ornaments for the neck, hands, and feet, namely crowns, earrings, bracelets, armlets, necklaces, half-necklaces, ear ornaments, finger rings, golden chains, belts, nets of gold, nets of pearls, and nets of little bells made of every kind of jewel, whatever ornaments they wish for, they see the buddha field filled with just such ornaments, adorned with many hundreds of thousands of jewels and hanging from jewel trees, and they know themselves to be adorned with those ornaments.

Whatever kind of palace they wish for, of whatever color, emblem, shape, height and breadth, adorned with hundreds of thousands of turrets of various jewels, with jeweled thrones spread with various divine cloths and furnished with multicolored cushions, just such palaces appear before them. Within those jeweled palaces that have appeared, each of them dwells surrounded and honored by seven thousand goddesses, and they play, delight, and enjoy themselves. In that world there is no difference between gods and humans, except that by conventional usage they are counted as "gods" and "humans."

Ānanda, it is like this. For example, in the presence of a universal monarch, a lowly person or a eunuch does not shine, does not glow, does not stand out, is not confident, and is not radiant. Likewise, in the presence of the gods of the Paranirmitavaśavartin heaven, even Śakra (Indra), lord of the gods, does not shine, does not glow, and does not stand out in his parks, palaces, clothing, ornaments, power, magical abilities, miracles, and sovereignty, except in the realization of the Dharma and the enjoyment of the Dharma. Ānanda, the people of the world Sukhāvatī should be regarded as being just like the gods of the Paranirmitavaśavartin heaven.

Ānanda, in that world Sukhāvatī, when the morning hour arrives, winds rise from all four directions, stirring everywhere and churning all around. They sway, sway all around, shake, and shake all around the jewel trees, which are bright, beautiful to behold, of distinct colors and of many colors, and perfumed with various exquisitely fragrant divine scents. From the trees, beautiful flowers of many kinds with delightful fragrances fall onto that great jeweled ground, and the whole of that buddhafield becomes strewn with those flowers to the depth of seven times a man's height. For example, when a man skilled in strewing flowers on the ground scatters them with both hands and lays them out evenly, they are very bright and beautiful to behold. In the same way, those flowers, possessed of fragrance and distinct colors, cover that entire buddhafield to the depth of about seven times a man's height. Those kinds of flowers are soft; to give just a comparison, they are pleasant to the touch like kācalindi cloth. When one sets down one's foot, they sink about four finger-widths, and when one lifts one's foot, they rise about four finger-widths. When the morning hour has passed, those flowers too disappear without remainder. After that, the buddhafield becomes clear, delightful, and clean, without any clutter from the earlier flowers. Then once more winds rise from all four directions and scatter fresh flowers that were not there before. As in the morning, so too at midday, in the afternoon, at night, at dusk, at midnight, and at dawn. When those winds, perfumed with various fragrances, rise and touch those beings, they come to possess a bliss like that of a monk who has entered the absorption of cessation.

Ānanda, in that buddhafield, except as the Tathāgata speaks of them, there is no designation at all by the names of fire, sun, moon, planets, constellations, the forms of stars, or darkness and pitch-black darkness. Nor is there any designation of day and night at all. Nor is there any notion at all of keeping a household.

Ānanda, in that world Sukhāvatī, from time to time rain falls from clouds of divine scented water. There falls a rain of divine flowers of every color, of the seven kinds of divine jewels, of divine sandalwood powder, and of divine parasols, victory banners, and flags. Divine canopies are held aloft, and divine jeweled parasols together with yak-tail fans are held in the sky. The melodious sounds of divine music resound, and goddesses dance.

Ānanda, all the beings who have been born and who will be born in that buddhafield are certain of rightness until they reach nirvāṇa. Why is that? Because there the two groups, the undetermined and those certain of

wrongness, are neither established nor designated.

Ānanda, in brief, it is for this reason that that world is called Sukhāvatī, and this is not the full account. Ānanda, were it taught in full, even if one were to recount the causes of happiness of the world Sukhāvatī until the eon came to an end, one could not reach the end of those causes of happiness.

Then, at that time, the Blessed One spoke these verses:

Even if all sentient beings had become sugatas,
Skilled in the ultimate meaning, their wisdom utterly pure,
And for an eon, or for longer still,
Were to proclaim the praises of Sukhāvatī,
As they recited their garlands of praise,
Those ten million eons would be exhausted,
Yet the praise of Sukhāvatī would not reach its end,
Nor would their eloquence be exhausted.

Were someone to shatter worlds as many as the finest atoms,
Crushing and grinding them into dust,
And fill with jewels still more worlds than that,
And give them all away in generosity,
That would not come to a fraction of the merit
Of one who, hearing the name of Immeasurable Light, Amitābha,
And the surpassing qualities of Sukhāvatī,
Rejoices and joins his palms.

Therefore, having heard the qualities of that Tathāgata,
Be glad and joyful,
And so as to go to Sukhāvatī, that supreme world,
Give rise to fervent aspiration.

To the merit of one who hears
The very name of the world Sukhāvatī,
All those vast and supreme fields
Do not compare, even in part.

Those who hold the Victor's word and possess wisdom
Will gain still greater merit than that.
Faith is the root for attaining the ultimate;
Therefore, having heard, cast off your doubts.

Ānanda, the qualities and the praises of the world Sukhāvatī are thus immeasurable.

Ānanda, in each of the ten directions, in buddha fields as numerous as the sands of the river Ganges, blessed buddhas as numerous as the sands of the river Ganges proclaim the name of that Blessed One, the Tathāgata Amitābha. They speak his praises. They spread his renown far and wide. They declare his qualities. Why is that? Because all those sentient beings who hear the name of that Blessed One Amitābha, and who, having heard it, give rise from the depths of their hearts to faith and joy for even a single moment of thought, will not turn back from unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening.

Ānanda, those sentient beings who in various ways bring that Tathāgata to mind again and again, who generate many immeasurable roots of virtue, who dedicate their minds to awakening and make the aspiration to be born in that world, will find, when the time of their death draws near, that the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly and completely awakened Buddha Amitābha stands before them, facing them, surrounded by many assemblies of monks. Having seen that Blessed One Amitābha, they will die and pass on with minds filled with clear faith, and will be born in that very world, Sukhāvatī.

Ānanda, any son or daughter of good family who thinks, "How wonderful it would be to see the Tathāgata Amitābha in this very life!" should give rise to the mind set on unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening. With the steady current of superior intention, they should wholly direct their minds toward being born in that buddha field, and they should generate roots of virtue and dedicate them.

Ānanda, those who bring that Tathāgata to mind, who continually generate many immeasurable roots of virtue, and who set their minds firmly on that buddha field, will find, when the time of their death draws near, that an emanation of the Buddha appears before them, just like the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly and completely awakened Buddha Amitābha in color, in shape, in height and breadth, and in his retinue, the Saṅgha of monks. Filled with clear faith at seeing the Tathāgata, through that meditative absorption focused on him and through unforgetting mindfulness, they will die and pass on and be born in that very buddha field.

Ānanda, those sentient beings who recollect that Tathāgata even for a single moment of thought and who wish to be born in that buddha field; who, when the profound Dharma is being taught, find joy in it and are not disheartened,

not dismayed and not daunted; and who bring that Tathāgata Amitābha to mind even for a single moment of thought and give rise to longing for him, will see that Tathāgata Amitābha in a dream and will be born in that world, Sukhāvatī. They will also become irreversible from unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening.

Ānanda, it is because those tathāgatas see this compelling benefit that, in countless, immeasurable worlds of the ten directions, they proclaim the name of that Tathāgata Amitābha, speak his praises and spread his eulogies.

Ānanda, from each of the ten directions, too, bodhisattvas as numerous as the sands of the river Ganges go to that buddha field in order to behold that Tathāgata Amitābha, to pay homage to him, to honor and serve him, and to question him, and in order to behold that assembly of bodhisattvas and those special and perfect arrays of the ornaments of qualities of that buddha field.

Then, at that time, the Blessed One, expounding this very point at length, spoke these verses:

To pay homage to the Buddha, the Guide Amitābha,
From the buddha fields of the east, as endless as the Ganges' sands,
Those perfected bodhisattvas came.
Bearing handfuls of many flowers of various colors,
Sweet-scented and delightful,
They scattered them over Amitāyus, worshipped by gods and humans,
The supreme Guide of humankind.

To pay homage to the Buddha, the Guide Amitābha,
Likewise from all the buddha fields of the south, the west
And the north, however many there are,
Those perfected bodhisattvas came.
Bearing handfuls of many incenses of various colors,
Sweet-scented and delightful,
They scattered them over Amitāyus, worshipped by gods and humans,
The supreme Guide of humankind.

Those many bodhisattvas
Made offerings, bowed at the feet of Amitābha,
Circumambulated him, and spoke these words:
"How wondrous and beautiful is this buddha field!"
With minds of joy and delight beyond measure,
They scattered handfuls of flowers,

And before that Guide they spoke these words:
"May our fields too become like this!"
The very moment they scattered those handfuls of flowers,
They became a parasol a hundred leagues across,
Finely adorned and beautiful with a shining handle,
Spread above, covering the Buddha's body entirely.
Those bodhisattvas likewise
Paid him honor and, rejoicing, spoke these words:
"Those beings who have heard the name of the Supreme Human
Have gained a fine gain indeed.
Since we have come to this buddha field,
What we gained before has been well gained.
Behold how this dreamlike field appears,
Which the Teacher accomplished over a thousand eons!
Boundless in light and boundless in splendor,
Boundless in life span, with a boundless Saṅgha,
Surrounded by bodhisattvas and made beautiful:
Behold the Buddha, the supreme heap of merit!"

Then Amitāyus smiled,
And thirty-six billion trillion rays of light
Came forth from the maṇḍala of his face
And pervaded thousands of millions of fields.
All those rays of light returned again
And dissolved into the crown of the Guide's head.
When the rays of light had dissolved,
Gods and humans felt great joy.
Then the Buddha's son of great renown,
Avalokiteśvara, rose and asked:
"For what reason does the Protector of the World smile?
Blessed One, what is its cause and its condition?
Compassionate one who benefits many beings by liberating them,
Expert in the ultimate, please explain this."

Hearing his supreme speech, pleasing and blissful,
beings come to have joyful minds.
Bodhisattvas from many world systems
who come here to Sukhāvatī to see the Buddha

hear those words and feel great joy,
and swiftly they come to behold this field.
Having arrived in this vast field,
they swiftly gain the divine eye and the divine ear,
recollection of former lives, supreme and skillful intelligence,
and the power of miraculous abilities as well.

The Buddha Amitāyus declared:
"In former times I made this aspiration:
If beings should hear my name,
may they always come to my field.
Because that excellent aspiration of mine has been fulfilled,
beings come from many world systems.
Once they have arrived in my field,
they become irreversible within a single birth.
Therefore any bodhisattva here who wishes,
'May my own field become like this,
and by my name, by my voice, and by the sight of me
may I set many beings free,'
should go swiftly, in great haste,
to the world system Sukhāvatī,
and, going into the presence of Amitābha,
make offerings to a thousand koṭis of buddhas."

By the power of miraculous abilities they go to many fields,
make offerings to many koṭis of buddhas,
and having made offerings to the Sugatas,
they return again to Sukhāvatī by the forenoon.

The third fascicle.

Ānanda, the bodhi tree of that Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Amitābha, is sixteen hundred yojanas in height. Its branches, leaves, and petals hang down as far as eight hundred yojanas, and the thickness and girth of its root measure five hundred yojanas. It is always in leaf, always in flower, and always in fruit. It is of various colors, of many hundreds of thousands of colors, with various leaves, various flowers, and various fruits. It is adorned with all manner of ornaments, illuminated by moonlike precious jewels, decorated with the precious jewels worn by Śakra (Indra), filled with

precious wish-fulfilling jewels, and exquisitely decorated with the supreme ocean jewels. Its color surpasses that of the gods. Golden threads hang from it, and it bears beautiful necklaces, clusters of jewels, garlands, single-strand necklaces, garlands of red pearls, garlands of blue pearls, and a multitude of girdles hanging from the mouths of lions. It is adorned with jewel threads, with every kind of jewel, and with conch shells. It is canopied with nets of gold, nets of pearls, nets of every kind of jewel, and nets of little bells. It is beautifully ornamented with makaras, auspicious emblems, swastikas, and crescent shapes, adorned with sparkling gems, with gold, and with every jewel ornament, and beautifully adorned in accordance with whatever beings perceive in their wishes.

Ānanda, when that bodhi tree is stirred by the wind, the sound that arises from it is made known throughout immeasurable world systems. Ānanda, know that those beings in whose ears the sound of that bodhi tree resounds will not be afflicted by disease of the ear until they reach awakening. Know that those immeasurable, countless, inconceivable, incomparable, unfathomable, limitless, and inexpressible beings before whose eyes that bodhi tree appears will not be afflicted by disease of the eye until they reach awakening. Ānanda, know that those beings who smell the fragrance of that bodhi tree will never be afflicted by disease of the nose until they reach awakening. Know that those beings who taste the flavor of the fruit of that bodhi tree will never be afflicted by disease of the tongue until they reach awakening. Know that those beings who are touched by the light of that bodhi tree will never be afflicted by disease of the body until they reach awakening. Ānanda, know that those beings who contemplate that bodhi tree with certainty as the nature of reality will, from this day on until they reach awakening, never have a distracted mind. All those beings, as soon as they see that bodhi tree, become irreversible from unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening.

Through the blessing of the former aspiration of that very Tathāgata Amitāyus, through the special service he rendered to the Victors of the past, and because his former aspiration and conduct were thoroughly complete, thoroughly cultivated, not meager, and without deficiency, they obtain the three kinds of patience, namely the patience that follows sound, the patience of conformity, and patience regarding unborn phenomena.

Ānanda, all those bodhisattvas who have been born, are being born, and will be born in that buddha field are bound to but one more birth, and will fully and perfectly awaken to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening, except

where the power of an aspiration decides otherwise. Those bodhisattvas, without exception, roar the great lion's roar, are clad in great armor, and strive to bring all beings to complete nirvāṇa.

Ānanda, the śrāvakas who dwell in that buddha field all have a radiance of one fathom. The bodhisattvas who dwell there all have a radiance of a hundred thousand koṭis of yojanas, except for two bodhisattvas whose light always, without interruption, pervades that world system with unceasing radiance.

Then the venerable Ānanda said to the Blessed One, "Blessed One, what are the names of those two bodhisattva great beings?"

The Blessed One said, "Ānanda, of those two, one is named the bodhisattva great being Avalokiteśvara, and the other is named Mahāsthāmaprāpta. Ānanda, these two passed away from this buddha field, transmigrated, and were born in that buddha field."

Ānanda, the bodhisattvas who are born in that buddhafield all possess the thirty-two marks of a great being. Their bodies are complete. They are skilled in meditative concentration and the superknowledges (abhijñā), and skilled in drawing distinctions through wisdom. Their faculties are sharp. Their faculties are restrained, and they possess the faculty of perfect knowledge. They are undaunted, their faculties are unmoving, and they have attained patience. Every one of them has endless, boundless good qualities.

Ānanda, the bodhisattvas who are born in that buddhafield are never apart from the sight of the buddhas, and every one of them is by nature unable to fall back until they reach awakening. From that point on, none of them will ever fail to remember their former lives; they will remember them. The only exceptions are those who, like me at present, made aspirations in the past to dwell in eons stirred up by the five degenerations, times such as these when buddhas, blessed ones, appear in the world.

Ānanda, the bodhisattvas who are born in that buddhafield all go to other world systems within a single morning and serve many millions of billions of buddhas, blessed ones. They think, "We shall make offerings with flowers, incense, lamps, perfumes, garlands, ointments, powders, garments, parasols, victory banners, pennants, cymbals, songs, and the sounds of music of such kinds as these." Whatever thoughts of this kind they form, and whatever they wish for, the moment they form the thought, all such offering articles appear in their hands through the power of the Buddha. With these, from the flowers through to the sounds of music, they make offerings to those buddhas, the

blessed ones, and they also produce and gather many roots of virtue, immeasurable and countless.

And if they wish, "May clusters of flowers of such kinds as these appear in our hands," the moment they form the thought, clusters of divine flowers of various colors and various scents, with many fragrances, appear in their hands. They scatter those clustered flowers of such kinds over those buddhas, the blessed ones; they strew them and shower them down. Of all the clustered flowers they scatter, even the smallest among them becomes a parasol of flowers some ten yojanas in size in the sky above, and the earlier ones do not fall to the ground until the very last has been scattered. Some of the clustered flowers scattered there become parasols twenty yojanas in size in the sky above. Some are thirty or forty yojanas in size. Some even become parasols of flowers in the sky above as large as a hundred thousand yojanas.

Then they give rise to joy and to vast, supreme joy, attain vast gladness of mind, and produce countless and immeasurable roots of virtue. Having served many hundreds of thousands of millions of billions of buddhas, they return within that single morning and dwell in the world system of Sukhāvatī. Their aspirations are accomplished because they are upheld by the blessing of the past aspirations of that Blessed One, the Tathāgata Amitāyus, and because of the hearing of the Dharma they gave in the past, the roots of virtue they produced toward the Victors of the past, and their past aspirations, which were fulfilled and complete, not few, thoroughly analyzed, and thoroughly cultivated.

Ānanda, the bodhisattvas who have been born in that buddhafield all speak discourses on the Dharma that are endowed with omniscience. The beings in that buddhafield do not give rise to any perception of possessiveness at all. As they all walk about and roam through that buddhafield, they give rise neither to delight nor to displeasure. When they go, they go without attachment, never with attachment. That is to say, grasping at things, the thought of a fixed abode, and thoughts of that kind never occur in them at all.

Ānanda, the bodhisattvas who are born in that world realm Sukhāvatī have no perception of others, no perception of their own, and no perception of a self. They have no quarrels, no disputes, no discord, and no mind of inequality. Toward all sentient beings they have a mind of equality, a beneficial mind, a loving mind, a tender mind, a gentle mind, a virtuous mind, a deeply serene mind, a steadfast mind, an unobstructed mind, an undisturbed mind, an

unclouded mind, and a mind that practices the conduct of the Perfection of Wisdom.

Their understanding has fully entered into the illusory nature of the mind-stream. They are equal to a great ocean of wisdom, and their intelligence is like Mount Meru. Having gathered many qualities, they delight in rightly advancing through the limbs of awakening and strive earnestly to advance rightly to buddhahood. Their fleshly eye discerns thoroughly. They accomplish the divine eye, they have fully realized the eye of wisdom, they have reached the far shore of the Dharma eye, and they accomplish the buddha eye. They explain and teach, teaching rightly and extensively, and they accomplish unattached wisdom. They strive for the sameness of the three realms. Their minds are tamed and their minds are at peace. They do not apprehend any phenomenon. They are skilled in the definitive explanations of origination and are possessed of the definitive explanations of the Dharma. They are skilled in what is clear and what is unclear, and skilled in what is proper and what is improper. They dwell without regard for worldly talk. Through supramundane discourse they realize the essence, and they are skilled in thoroughly investigating all phenomena. They dwell in the knowledge that all phenomena are by nature at peace. Their sphere of activity is without any object of reference. They possess nothing, grasp at nothing, have no intention, and have no aggregates. Being without grasping, they are utterly liberated. They are without afflictions. They abide without limit in the superknowledges and abide in what has no root. Their minds are without attachment and without dejection. They strive earnestly in the profound teachings and are never discouraged. They are exalted through entering the wisdom of the Buddha, which is so hard to fathom. They have attained the path that leads to one single goal and are free of doubt. They have passed beyond all hesitation. They do not depend on others for their knowledge, and they are without arrogance.

Exalted in wisdom, they are like Mount Meru. With their undisturbed understanding, they are like the ocean. Through the light of wisdom, through their minds that are white, utterly white, pure and virtuous, and through the supreme quality of their light, which shines with the color of refined gold, they far surpass the light of the sun and moon. Because they bear with the virtue and nonvirtue of all sentient beings, they are like the earth. Because they flow forth to wash away the stains of the afflictions, they are like water. Because they burn away all conceited notions about phenomena and burn up the

afflictions, they are like the king of fire. Because they are unattached to all the world, they are like the wind. Because they have thoroughly penetrated all phenomena and because nothing whatsoever exists anywhere, they are like space. Because they are unstained by all the world, they are like the lotus. Because they proclaim what is Dharma and what is not, they are like the great thunder that comes in its season. Because they pour down the rain of the water of Dharma, they are like a great rainstorm. Because they outshine great assemblies, they are like a bull. Because their minds are supremely tamed, they are like a great elephant. Because they are thoroughly tamed, they are like a fine thoroughbred horse. Because through their prowess and fearlessness they know no fear, they are like the lion, king of beasts. Because they protect all sentient beings, they are like the banyan, king of trees. Because they are unmoved by all opponents, they are like Meru, king of mountains. Because they cultivate immeasurable loving-kindness, they are like space. Because they go at the forefront in mastery of all virtuous qualities, they are like the Great Brahmā. Because they hoard nothing in their dwellings, they are like birds. Because they vanquish all opponents, they are like the garuḍa, king of birds. Because they so rarely appear, they are like the udumbara flower.

Like elephants, they are well settled in meditative equipoise and so are undistracted. Their faculties are not dull. They are skilled in ascertaining the meaning, and they abound in patience and certainty. Because they wish for the good fortune of others, they are without jealousy. They are fearless in discussions of the Dharma and insatiable in seeking the Dharma. In moral discipline they are like beryl. In learning they are like a mine of jewels. Their voices are sweet with the great sound of the drum of Dharma. They beat the great drum of Dharma, blow the great conch of Dharma, raise the great victory banner of Dharma, hold aloft the great flag of Dharma, and set ablaze the great lamp of Dharma.

Seeing with wisdom, they are free of delusion. They are without aversion, their mental barrenness subdued. They are pure, without foulness, and without greed. They delight in giving out, they have given away what is to be given, and their hands are open in generosity. They delight in sharing both the Dharma and material things, and in giving they are without stinginess. They are unmixed with defilement, without fear in their minds, and without attachment. They are steadfast and heroic. They hold others dear, they are endowed with devotion, and they are endowed with a sense of shame. They

have drawn out the thorn, they are without barriers, and they have attained the superknowledges. They are gentle and pleasant to be with. They work for others' benefit, they illuminate the world, and they are guides. They have abandoned the craving for pleasure, clinging, and anger. They are pure, free of sorrow, and stainless, having abandoned the three stains. They delight in the superknowledges. They have the power of their causes and the power of their aspirations. They are not inferior and they are without deceit. They have generated roots of virtue under many hundreds of thousands of millions of billions of buddhas. They have extracted the thorn of pride. They are free of attachment, aversion and delusion. They are pure and devoted to virtue. They are praised by the holy Victors, skilled in the ways of the world, and have fully accomplished trained wisdom. Lauded by the Victor, their minds are filled with joy. They are courageous and able to endure. They are unequaled, without mental barrenness, immeasurable, and free of dust. Their gatherings are vast, and they have become leaders like bulls. They speak the truth. They are endowed with understanding, endowed with mindfulness, endowed with intelligence, and endowed with realization. They wield the weapon of wisdom. They are endowed with merit and endowed with radiance. They are free of mental barrenness, stains and anger. Ever diligent in the Dharma,

All of them have learning in all dharmas as vast as the ocean.

Ānanda, in brief, the bodhisattvas of that buddhafield are all like this. If one were to describe them at length, even if one taught for hundreds of thousands of koṭis of niyutas of eons, living for the lifespan of a tathāgata, one could not reach the end of the qualities of those holy beings, and the Tathāgata's fearless confidence would never run out. Why is that? Ānanda, it is because the qualities of those bodhisattvas and the unsurpassed wisdom and eloquence of the Tathāgata are both inconceivable and beyond compare.

Ānanda, rise, turn to face the west, scatter flowers, join your palms, and bow toward that direction where the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Amitābha, stainless and utterly pure, dwells, lives, sustains himself, and teaches the Dharma. His name, too, is renowned without obstruction throughout the ten directions. In each direction, buddhas, blessed ones, as many as the grains of sand in the river Ganges, whose speech is free of attachment and free of hindrance, speak his praises and extol him, not merely a few times, and they speak of him melodiously.

When he had said this, the venerable Ānanda said to the Blessed One, "Blessed One, I wish to behold that Tathāgata, the Arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Amitābha, the one of Immeasurable Life, and those bodhisattva great beings who have cultivated roots of virtue under many hundreds of thousands of koṭis of niyutas of buddhas."

The very moment the venerable Ānanda had spoken these words, at that instant, that Tathāgata, the Arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha, sent forth from the palm of his hand a light such that a hundred thousand koṭis of buddhafields became pervaded by its radiance. At that time, in all those hundred thousand koṭis of buddhafields, whatever black mountains, jewel mountains, Sumerus, great Sumerus, Mucilinda mountains, great Mucilinda mountains, Cakravāḍa ranges, great Cakravāḍa ranges, walls, pillars, dense trees, gardens, and palaces there were, and whatever gods and humans there were, all of them were overwhelmed and outshone by the light of that Tathāgata Amitābha.

Just as, for example, after the sun has risen, one person can see another person standing about a fathom away, so too at that time, through the power of the Buddha and because that light was utterly pure, the monks, nuns, laymen, and laywomen, the gods, nāgas, yakṣas, gandharvas, asuras, garuḍas, kiṃnaras, mahoragas, humans, and nonhumans, from this buddhafield beheld the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Amitābha, towering above all buddhafields like Sumeru, the king of mountains, outshining every direction, blazing, radiant, and resplendent in his beauty, along with that great assembly of bodhisattvas and that saṅgha of monks.

For example, if this great earth were to become a single expanse of water, there would be no trees, no mountains, no islands, no grasses, shrubs, herbs, or forests, no rivers, and no chasms or precipices would appear; there would be nothing other than the great earth become a single ocean. In the same way, in that buddhafield there is no other sign or feature whatsoever apart from the light a fathom wide that issues from the bodies of the śrāvakas and the light of the bodhisattvas, which extends for hundreds of thousands of koṭis of yojanas. The Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Amitābha, outshining that assembly of śrāvakas and that assembly of bodhisattvas, appears clearly in every direction.

At that time, to all the bodhisattvas, śrāvakas, and pratyekabuddhas, and to all those gods and humans in that world Sukhāvatī, this Sahā world became

visible, and so did the Tathāgata Śākyamuni, surrounded by a great saṅgha of monks and teaching the Dharma.

Then the Blessed One said to the bodhisattva great being Ajita (Maitreya), "Ajita, do you see this perfect array of the ornaments of qualities of that buddhafield? Do you see, in the sky above, the delightful pleasure groves, the delightful forests, the delightful parks, the rivers, and the delightful ponds filled with jewel flowers, lotuses, kumudas, and white lotuses? Do you see how, from the ground below up to the realm of Akaniṣṭha, the expanse of the sky is strewn with flowers, adorned all over with garlands of flowers, filled with bright garlands of various jewels, and frequented by birds of many kinds emanated by the Tathāgata?"

He replied, "Blessed One, I see them."

The Blessed One said, "Ajita, do you see the other flocks of birds, which fill all buddhafields with their song, and through which those bodhisattvas are never parted from recollection of the Buddha?"

He replied, "Blessed One, I see them."

The Blessed One said, "Ajita, do you see those beings in this buddhafield who, having entered palaces a hundred thousand yojanas in size, travel through the sky without hindrance?"

He replied, "Blessed One, I see them."

The Blessed One said, "Ajita, what do you think? Is there any difference between the gods who wield power over others' emanations (Paranirmitavaśavartin) and the humans born in the world Sukhāvatī?"

He replied, "Blessed One, I do not see even a single difference. The humans of that world Sukhāvatī are equal to them in everything, up to and including great miraculous power."

The Blessed One said, "Ajita, do you see that in that world Sukhāvatī some people dwell within the wombs of great lotuses?"

He replied, "Blessed One, just as, for example, the gods of the Heaven of the Thirty-Three and the Yāma gods enter celestial palaces fifty leagues, a hundred leagues, or five hundred leagues in size, and there play, enjoy themselves and amuse themselves, in the same way, Blessed One, I see some people of that world Sukhāvatī dwelling within the wombs of great lotuses. Blessed One, there are also beings there who are born miraculously, appearing

seated cross-legged on lotuses. Blessed One, what is the cause, and what is the condition, that some dwell within the wombs of lotuses while others are born miraculously, seated cross-legged on lotuses?"

The Blessed One said, "Ajita, those bodhisattvas who dwell in other buddha fields and, with minds fallen into doubt, generate roots of virtue in order to be born in the world Sukhāvatī, dwell there within wombs. Those who are without doubt and without hesitation, who generate roots of virtue in order to be born in the world Sukhāvatī, and who trust in, have faith in and are devoted to the unattached wisdom of the buddhas, the blessed ones, are born miraculously, seated cross-legged on lotuses.

"Ajita, those bodhisattva great beings dwelling in other buddha fields who give rise to the intention to see, to pay homage to and to attend upon the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Complete Buddha Amitābha, who give rise to no doubt, who have no hesitation about the unattached wisdom of the Buddha, and who accumulate their own roots of virtue, come to be born miraculously, seated cross-legged. Just as, for example, with other bodhisattvas not long born, in a single instant their bodies take on such a form.

"Ajita, look at the distinction in wisdom and the gradation of wisdom: namely, at the deficient wisdom and the meager wisdom of those who, by attending to perceptions fallen into doubt, are thus deprived for five hundred years of seeing the Buddha, and deprived of seeing bodhisattvas, of hearing the Dharma, of Dharma discourse, of virtuous conduct, and of all excellence of virtue.

"Ajita, suppose, for example, that a king, an anointed kṣatriya, had a chamber adorned with gold and every kind of beryl, hung with silks, garlands and clusters of tassels, with canopies of various colors stretched above, fine cloth spread out, various loose flowers strewn about, perfumed with abundant incense, adorned with mansions, cool pavilions, windows, parapets, porticoes and balconies of every kind of jewel, covered with nets of golden and jeweled bells and little bells, square and symmetrical, with four pillars set up, four doors fitted and four stairways. Suppose that a son of that king, having committed an offense, were put into that chamber and placed within an inner enclosure of Jambū River gold, and that a couch were arranged for him there, its seat spread with a woolen rug, with quilted covers and palalika cloths laid upon it, a covering of cloth from the land of Kaliṅga spread over it, silk spread

on top of that, and red cushions placed on both the right and the left, bright and lovely to behold, so that he might sit or lie on it as he pleased; and suppose many different kinds of pure and delicious food and drink were set out for him. Ajita, what do you think of this? Is the enjoyment of that prince abundant?"

He replied, "Blessed One, it is abundant."

The Blessed One said, "Ajita, what do you think of this? Does he relish it? Does he swallow it? Does he find joy in it?"

He replied, "No, Blessed One. He longs to be freed from the chamber into which the king consigned him because of his offense, and he seeks out noblemen, young men of noble family, ministers, the women of the queen's retinue, chief merchants, householders, provincial kings, or anyone at all through whom he might be freed from that chamber. Blessed One, that prince has no joy in that prison, and he will not be freed until the king permits it."

The Blessed One said, "Ajita, in the same way, those bodhisattvas who generate roots of virtue while fallen into doubt, and who hesitate about the wisdom of the buddhas, the wisdom that is unequaled and equal to the unequaled, are born in that world Sukhāvatī through hearing the Buddha's name and through mere serene faith of mind; yet they are not born miraculously, seated cross-legged on lotuses, but rather experience dwelling within the wombs of lotuses. There they dwell, perceiving those wombs as parks and celestial palaces. There is no excrement or urine, no saliva, no mucus, and nothing disagreeable arises; yet for five hundred years they are separated from seeing the Buddha, hearing the Dharma, seeing bodhisattvas, ascertaining the related Dharma discourses, and all practice of virtuous dharmas. They take no delight there and find no satisfaction. When their former fault is exhausted, they emerge from the wombs of the lotuses; yet even when they have emerged, they do not know whether they have emerged above, below, or straight across.

"Ajita, look how, during those five hundred years, attending upon many hundreds of thousands of koṭis of niyutas of buddhas, generating many roots of virtue, countless, measureless and incalculable, and upholding the immeasurable qualities of a buddha, all of this failed to be accomplished because of the fault of doubt. Ajita, look how great a harm doubt becomes for bodhisattvas. Ajita, therefore bodhisattvas should completely abandon doubt and give rise to the mind of awakening, and, in order swiftly to attain the

might that produces the power of benefit and happiness for all sentient beings, they should fully dedicate their roots of virtue to being born in the world Sukhāvatī, where the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Complete Buddha Amitābha dwells."

When the Blessed One had spoken thus, the bodhisattva Ajita said this to the Blessed One:

"Blessed One, how many bodhisattvas who are fully accomplished will be born in the Sukhāvatī world realm from this buddha field, and from the presence of the blessed buddhas of other buddha fields?"

The Blessed One said, "Ajita (Maitreya), seventy-two trillion fully accomplished bodhisattvas will be born in the Sukhāvatī world realm from this buddha field. They have produced roots of virtue under many hundreds of thousands of trillions of buddhas, and so they are fully accomplished as irreversible. What need is there even to mention those whose roots of virtue are lesser than that?

"From the presence of the Tathāgata Duṣprasaha, eighteen trillion bodhisattvas will be born in the Sukhāvatī world realm. In the northeastern direction there dwells the Tathāgata called Ratnākara, and from his presence nine hundred million bodhisattvas will be born in the Sukhāvatī world realm. From the presence of the Tathāgata Jyotiṣprabha, two hundred and twenty million bodhisattvas will be born in the Sukhāvatī world realm. From the presence of the Tathāgata Amitasvara, two hundred and fifty million bodhisattvas will be born in the Sukhāvatī world realm. From the presence of the Tathāgata Lokapradīpa, six hundred million bodhisattvas will be born in the Sukhāvatī world realm. From the presence of the Tathāgata Nāgābhibhū, six hundred and forty million bodhisattvas will be born in the Sukhāvatī world realm. From the presence of the Tathāgata Virajaprabha, two hundred and fifty million bodhisattvas will be born in the Sukhāvatī world realm. From the presence of the Tathāgata Siṃha, eighteen thousand bodhisattvas will be born in the Sukhāvatī world realm. From the presence of the Tathāgata Śrīkūṭa, eight hundred and ten million bodhisattvas will be born in the Sukhāvatī world realm. From the presence of the Tathāgata Narendra, ten trillion bodhisattvas will be born in the Sukhāvatī world realm. From the presence of the Tathāgata Balābhijña, twenty-two thousand bodhisattvas will be born in the Sukhāvatī world realm. From the presence of the Tathāgata Puṣpadhvaja, two hundred and fifty million bodhisattvas will be born in the Sukhāvatī world realm: bodhisattvas who have attained diligence, who have entered fully by a single

entry, and who in a single span of eight days have cast off the saṃsāra of ninety-nine hundred thousand trillion eons. From the presence of the Tathāgata Jvalanādhipati, one hundred and twenty million bodhisattvas will be born in the Sukhāvatī world realm. From the presence of the Tathāgata Vaiśāradyaprāpta, six hundred and ninety million bodhisattvas will be born in the Sukhāvatī world realm in order to see the Tathāgata Amitābha, to bow to him, to venerate him, to inquire of him, and to put questions to him.

"Ajita, in this way, even if one were to recite for a full trillion eons the names of those tathāgatas from whose presence those bodhisattvas go to the Sukhāvatī world realm in order to see, bow to, and venerate the Tathāgata Amitābha, one could not reach the end of them.

"Ajita, see how well those beings have gained whatever they have gained who hear the name of the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Complete Buddha Amitābha! Those beings who gain even a single thought of faith in the Tathāgata Amitābha, and whose faith in this Dharma discourse is unshakable, will not incline toward the lesser.

"Therefore, Ajita, you should have faith and you should understand. Before the world with its gods, its māras and its Brahmās, and its population of ascetics and brahmins, you should take up this Dharma discourse, keep it, read it, master it, teach it correctly and extensively to others as well, and delight in meditating on it. Ajita, even for a single day and night one should take up and keep this Dharma discourse, read it and master it, and from the depths of one's heart explain it correctly and extensively to others as well. At the very least one should write it out well in a volume and keep it, and one should also generate toward it the perception that it is the Teacher.

"Whoever wishes swiftly to establish immeasurable beings in irreversibility from unsurpassed, perfectly complete awakening, to see the Blessed One, the Tathāgata Amitāyus, and himself to take hold of the excellent, perfect, and superior array of the ornaments of the qualities of a buddha field, should cross over a great trichiliocosm world realm completely filled with fire in order to hear this Dharma discourse; he should hear this Dharma discourse. And having heard it, with a mind that does not waver, he should rejoice in it from the depths of his heart. He should undertake great and mighty diligence in order to take up this Dharma discourse, to master it, to keep it, to write it down, and to meditate on it. Even for as long as it takes to milk a cow once, he should recite it to others. And even after crossing that great trichiliocosm

world realm completely filled with fire, he should not give rise to even a single thought of regret. Why is that? Ajita, it is because many trillions of bodhisattvas, by listening to this vast Dharma discourse of this kind, become irreversible from unsurpassed, perfectly complete awakening.

In times to come, until the true Dharma has utterly perished, there will be sentient beings in whose ears this kind of vast Dharma discourse resounds. It is thoroughly praised by all the buddhas, extolled by all the buddhas, and approved by all the buddhas, and it swiftly brings about the great wisdom of omniscience. Those beings have gained a gain that is excellently gained. They have produced roots of virtue, they have rendered special service to the Victors of the past, and they will be blessed by the blessing of the buddhas. Those who, having heard it, attain joy and vast supreme joy, who take it up, retain it, read it, master it, teach it extensively to others as well, and come to delight in meditating on it, and even those who merely write it down and make offerings to it, will also produce a great deal of merit, merit that is not easy to count.

Ajita, in this way I have done what a Tathāgata does. Now you too must strive, free of doubt. Do not entertain any doubt about the wisdom of the Buddha, which is unattached and unobstructed, lest you end up in a prison of jewels, even one endowed with the supreme of every kind. Ajita, the appearance of a buddha is hard to find. The teaching of the Dharma is hard to find. The perfect freedoms are hard to find. Ajita, I have explained to you the perfection of all roots of virtue; now you must apply yourself and accomplish it. Ajita, so that this Dharma discourse will not be wasted, I make a great entrustment of it. Strive so that the Buddha's Dharma does not decline. Do not distort the command of the Tathāgata, lest for a long time it lead to harm, to what is not beneficial, to unhappiness, to suffering, and to falling into ruin.

Then, at that time, the Blessed One spoke these verses:

Those who have not made merit
Will never hear such teachings as these.
Those heroes who have reached accomplishment
Will hear these words.

Those who have seen the perfect Buddha,
The Light-Maker, protector of the world,
And have heard the Dharma with reverence,
Will attain the supreme joy.

Those attached to views, the inferior, and the faint-hearted
Cannot find faith in the Buddha's Dharma.
Those who have made offerings to the buddhas of the past
Train in the conduct of the protectors of the world.

Just as a blind man in a dark cave
Does not even know the path, so how could he show it?
So too, all the śrāvakas do not understand
The wisdom of the Buddha; what need to speak of other beings?

Only buddhas know the qualities of a buddha;
Not gods, nāgas, asuras, yakṣas, or śrāvakas.
Even the path of the pratyekabuddhas
Is not the full explanation of the Buddha's wisdom.

Even if all sentient beings became sugatas,
Learned in pure wisdom and in the ultimate,
And for an eon or even longer
Proclaimed the qualities of a single buddha,
They would pass completely into nirvāṇa;
And though they proclaimed them for many koṭis of eons,
They would not find the measure of the Buddha's wisdom.
So marvelous is the wisdom of the Victor.

Therefore the wise person, whose nature is understanding,
Who places trust in my words,
Having mastered the heap of the Victor's wisdom,
Declares in words, "The Buddha alone knows."

Only rarely is a human body found,
Only rarely does a buddha appear,
Faith and wisdom are found only after a long time;
Therefore, to attain the goal, generate diligence.

Whoever hears such supreme Dharma as this
Will attain joy in recollecting the Sugata.
Those who generate devotion to the awakening of the buddhas
Were my friends in times past.

When this Dharma discourse was taught, for twelve koṭis of sentient beings the Dharma eye regarding phenomena became pure, free of dust and without stain. Twenty-four koṭis attained the fruit of non-returning. The minds of eight

hundred monks were liberated from the defilements without grasping. Twenty-five koṭis of bodhisattvas attained acceptance of the non-arising of phenomena. Forty koṭis of a hundred thousand niyutas of koṭis of gods and humans, who had not generated the mind before, generated the mind set on unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, and dedicated their roots of virtue to rebirth in Sukhāvatī, in order to see, pay homage to, and attend upon the Blessed One, the Tathāgata Amitābha. All of them, after being born there, will gradually complete the conduct of a bodhisattva, and in other buddha fields will fully awaken into unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening as tathāgatas called Mañjusvara. Eighty koṭis of niyutas who had attained acceptance from the Tathāgata Dīpaṃkara and are irreversible from unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, whom the Tathāgata Amitābha, while formerly practicing the conduct of a bodhisattva, had brought to maturity for unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, will also be born in the world realm of Sukhāvatī and will fulfill their former aspirations and conduct.

At that time this great trichiliocosm world realm shook in six ways, and miracles of every kind appeared everywhere. Mandārava flowers were strewn over the ground knee-deep. The music of gods and humans resounded. Even as far as the abode of Akaniṣṭha the sound of "We rejoice!" resounded.

When the Blessed One had spoken thus, the bodhisattva mahāsattva Ajita, the venerable Ānanda, that entire assembly, and the world with its gods, humans, asuras, and gandharvas rejoiced and praised what the Blessed One had said.

From the Dharma discourse of the noble Great Heap of Jewels in one hundred thousand chapters, this concludes the fifth chapter, called The Array of the Qualities of the Buddha Field of the Tathāgata Amitābha.

It was translated and edited by the Indian preceptors Jinamitra and Dānaśīla and the chief editor and translator, the venerable Yeshé Dé, and was then revised and finalized according to the new language standard.

Herein is contained volume Kha of the Heap of Jewels (Ratnakūṭa).

Translator's Notes

• The elder rendered "the Accomplished One" translates Tibetan grub po, which I could not identify with confidence with a Sanskrit name in the standard list of this sūtra's audience; it is translated by meaning. The final sentence, in which the wisdom and vision of countless buddhas are gathered together, is terse in the Tibetan. The next piece explains it as showing that the Tathāgata's wisdom and vision are unobstructed.
• Apart from Dīpaṃkara, the names of the past tathāgatas are given in English translation of

the Tibetan rather than reconstructed Sanskrit, since this Tibetan list does not match the extant Sanskrit lists closely enough for confident reconstruction. Several names recur in the list exactly as in the Tibetan, among them Glorious Heap, Sandalwood Fragrance and Voice of Brahmā. The rendering "Gainer of a Host" for sde brnyes is tentative.

• The line rendered "Though I should go to the hell of ceaseless torment and dwell there always" reads literally "I, being without interval (mtshams med), shall always dwell." I take mtshams med as referring to the Avīci hell, as in the Sanskrit parallel of this vow. It could also simply mean "ceaselessly."

• The recurring number "bye ba khrag khrig brgya stong" renders the Sanskrit koṭi-niyuta-śatasahasra, given here as "hundred thousand koṭis of niyutas." In the second vow the Tibetan's double negative ("as long as they would not not fall") is rendered by its plain sense: the vow is that beings born there never again fall into the lower realms.

• "Firmly settled in the true state" renders □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□ (Skt. samyaktvaniyata), the assurance of reaching nirvāṇa. In the eleventh vow, the Tibetan places the list of exceptions in the middle of the vow, before the main clause. The English gives the vow first and then the exceptions, which keeps the long list readable. "Bound to just one more birth" renders □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□ (ekajātipratibaddha).

• Several gem names are rendered by their usual equivalents: spug as agate, "stone essence" (Skt. aśmagarbha) as emerald, men shel as crystal and shel as quartz. The fifth vow here is phrased, as the Tibetan stands, as beings perceiving the diverse colors of the adornments, which differs somewhat from the Sanskrit parallel about the adornments being beyond measure.

• In this passage □□□□□□□□□□ means "limitless, immeasurable," not "valid cognition." In the robe vow, □□□□□□□□ is taken as "properly stitched" in the sense of the patterned panels of a monastic robe, and the phrase □□□□□□□□□□□□□ is read as "as I wish." The idiom □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□ is rendered according to the evident sense of the parallel Sanskrit, namely that the samādhi does not lapse in between.

• The final line of the verses, "he will become a buddha in the world," is terse in the Tibetan. It is most likely the proclamation or confirmation that accompanies the miraculous signs. In the verse beginning "With light most vast," the phrase rendered "I, the protector" could also be read as "the protector's [light]."

• The large numbers follow the Tibetan units: koṭi (ten million) is rendered "ten million", a hundred koṭis "a billion", a thousand koṭis "ten billion", a hundred thousand koṭis "a trillion", and the compound koṭi-niyuta-śatasahasra is rendered conventionally as "a hundred thousand billion trillion". The Blessed One's reply continues into the next piece.

• The units in the list of great numbers are names of specific large numerals. Bimbara, kaṅkara, nayuta, akṣobhya and vivāha follow the usual Sanskrit equivalents. "Trillions," "flowing streams" and "victories" render units whose Sanskrit equivalents could not be fixed with confidence, so their meanings are translated instead. The text reads "these two" with a misspelling (gnyig for gnyis), and "gyis mchod pa" ("worshipped by number") where the sense plainly requires "not determinable by number." Both are read as copyists' slips.

• In the sentence on the golden trees, the Tibetan as written says "the roots are made of silver" after already listing the roots as gold; the parallel pattern of every following sentence (each tree's fruit being of the next jewel) shows this should read "fruits," and it is translated so. Here □□□□□□□ means "made of, consisting of," not the philosophical "intrinsic nature." The jewel names □□□□ (Skt. musāragalva) and □□□□□□□□□□□□ (Skt. aśmagarbha) are of uncertain identity; they are rendered conventionally as "coral" and "emerald."

• The gem names follow common identifications: "emerald" for Tibetan rdo'i snying po (Skt. aśmagarbha) and "agate" for spug (Skt. musāragalva), whose exact identity is disputed. The phrase "a hundred thousand yojanas" could also be read as "a hundred and a thousand

yojanas."
• □□□□□□□ (here "rippling waters") is uncertain; it seems to describe the stirring or bubbling surface of the rivers where the birds gather.
• "Certain of rightness," "undetermined," and "certain of wrongness" are the three classes of beings (samyaktvaniyata, aniyata, mithyātvaniyata): in Sukhāvatī only the first exists, so every being there is assured of reaching nirvāṇa. The word rendered "eunuch" is a reading of the Tibetan ma ṭha zama; it may instead mean simply a wretched or deformed person.
• The text reads □□□□□□□□□□ ("obtain difficulty"), which does not fit the context. It has been translated as □□□□□□□□□□ ("find joy"), the reading the parallel Sanskrit (tuṣṭi) supports. The number □□□□□□□□□□□□□□ (koṭi-niyuta) denotes an enormous figure, rendered approximately as "billion trillion."
• The verse line rendered "they become irreversible within a single birth" reads literally "from one birth they do not turn back"; it may also be understood as "bound to only one more birth, they do not turn back," in keeping with the prose that follows. The clause "except where the power of an aspiration decides otherwise" refers to bodhisattvas who, by special vow, choose to delay their awakening for the sake of beings.
• "Millions of billions" renders the Tibetan compound of very large numbers (koṭi-niyuta); the exact magnitudes are not fixed in English. "Clusters of flowers" renders a term of uncertain exact sense, probably a bunch or basket of flowers (Skt. puṣpapuṭa).
• □□□ is rendered "mental barrenness" following its standard equivalence with Sanskrit khila (obduracy of mind). The number □□□ is rendered loosely as "many hundreds of thousands of millions of billions", since □□□□□□□□ denotes a very large count whose exact value varies in the sources. The passage ends mid-sentence and continues in the next piece.
• In the description of the sky above, the text reads "nyams dga' bdag" ("self"), which makes no sense here; it has been read as the plural marker "dag". The verb "phyag 'tshol" has likewise been read as "phyag 'tshal" ("bow"). The mountain names Mucilinda and Cakravāḍa follow the standard Sanskrit equivalents of the Tibetan terms in the parallel Sukhāvatīvyūha list.
• "There are also beings born miraculously" reads the evident □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□ for the written □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□, which does not construe as "I". The fabric terms □□□□□□□□□□ ("quilted covers") and □□□□□□□□ ("palalika cloths") are uncertain; the first is rendered by sense, the second left as transliterated. Ajita here is the bodhisattva Maitreya.
• "Trillion" renders the compound bye ba khrag khrig (Sanskrit koṭīniyuta), an immense numeral whose exact value varies between systems; it is used here consistently as a conventional equivalent. "In a single span of eight days" follows the Tibetan literally. "With a mind that does not waver" renders the obscure phrase g.yor ma ltung ba'i rgyud kyis, whose exact sense is uncertain. Ajita is the epithet of the bodhisattva Maitreya.
• In the final verse, the Tibetan reads "they were now and friends in times past"; the Sanskrit parallel ("they were my friends in past times") indicates that "now" is a slip for the first-person pronoun "I/my," and the translation follows that reading. The "prison of jewels" alludes to the earlier teaching that those who doubt the Buddha's wisdom are born in Sukhāvatī enclosed in lotus palaces, unable to see the Buddha for a long time. "Light-Maker" renders an epithet of the Buddha (Skt. prabhaṃkara).
• This line is not part of the sūtra. It is the title marker of the Kangyur volume, which is designated by the Tibetan letter Kha, the second volume of the Ratnakūṭa section.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.